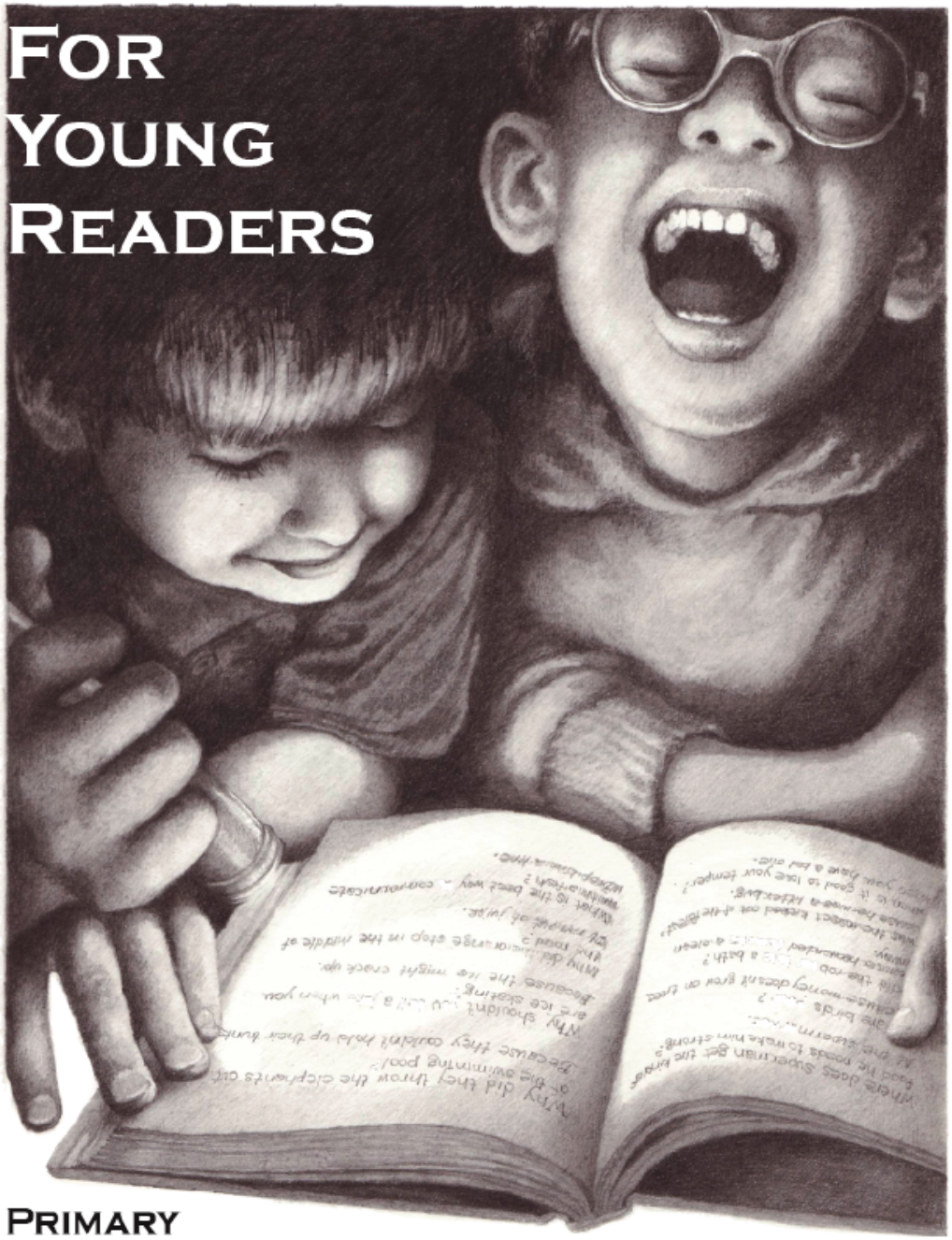
# New Books For Young Readers 2010



Primary

Intermediate

Adolescent

College of Education + Human Development

University of Minnesota

**Edited by Rebecca Rapport, University of Minnesota**

## Reviews by:

Leona Anderson, Beth Brendler, Erin,Buhr, Lauren Causey, Lee Galda, Sarah Hansen, Alice Maday, Patsy Mogush, Larry Peterson, Tracy Preece, Rebecca,Rapport, Julie Reimer, Wendy Woodfill, Pei-Ying Wu

## Cover Design and Illustration by Karen Ritz

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# Preschool

*A Book of Sleep* by Il Sung Na.
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Informational Science. Preschool. 0. 0375862234



The breathtaking illustrations grasp hold of the reader from the moment you open this book. It is a simple story about the differences between how animals sleep. Did you know that some animals sleep alone, some huddled together, some while on the move, and some with their eyes open? While learning interesting facts about animals, the fascinating, textured illustrations encourage the reader to pause and wonder about each slumbering animal. This is a rare book that embraces the reader and draws them into a peaceful and sleepy world. With his rich illustrations and calm words, Il Sung Na has created the perfect bedtime story to help a child peacefully drift off to sleep.

*A Small Surprise* by Louise Yates.
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0375856986




A celebration of being small for all young readers. On the cover pages, a tiny bunny sees a sign - “Jobs Available Apply Within: Small Animals Need Not Apply” - outside of a circus. The bunny goes on to prove that being small might mean needing help with tying shoes or wiping noses, but it has its upside too. Louise Yates has created a cast of large animals to skeptically surround her tiny hero as she dazzles them with the magical ability to disappear and reappear. With soft, expressive illustrations and simple, direct language, Yates’ picture book debut is perfect for all those small ones in your life who make a big impression.

*Always* by Alison McGhee, Pascal Lemaitre (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 1416974814



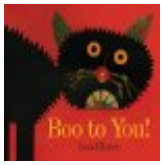

A tiny dog proclaims himself "the keeper of the castle" and lists all the feats he will perform to keep his little girl safe. Soft pencil drawings show the pup "guarding against monsters" (a spider dangling from its web) and keeping away "savage beasts" (who are in fact mice), among other duties. Any young child who has a dog knows how comforting their love and loyalty can be, even during a lightning storm. This book will be a comfort as well.

*Beach Day!* by Anahid Hamparian, Kristin Sorra (Illustrator).
Marshall Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $7.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Preschool. 0. 0761455302




The perfect beach book for infants and toddlers. Anahid Hamparian perceptively grasps the obsession that early talkers have with greeting everything they meet. The toddler in this book introduces the reader to all the important elements of a day at the beach as she greets them, from "Hello, umbrella!" to "Hello, sandcastles!" A wonderful introduction to the beach for first time beach goers and a fun review for those who have already been.

*Boo to You!* by Lois Ehlert.
Beach Lane Books. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 1416986251




Summer's ended, and it's time for the mice and their friends to celebrate the harvest, but how can they do that with that scary, meat-loving cat on the prowl? Never fear; these clever mice come up with the perfect solution to their cat problem! Ehlert uses photos of all kinds of fall vegies and seeds (identified at the end of the story), various kinds of textured paper and string to create her appealing collages. Her rhyming text is meant to be read aloud to children who will want to hold their own harvest party after hearing the story. "Pumpkin Talk" shares ideas for creating jack-o'-lanterns along with the recipe for roasting their seeds.

*Chicken and Cat Clean Up* by Sara Varon.
Scholastic Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0439634083




Best friends Chicken and Cat return in another wordless story that begins with a series of Cat's disasters while working for Chicken's housekeeping services company and ends triumphantly when Cat captures a bold lawbreaker who, of course, just happens to be a thieving and lying mouse. Young children will enjoy "reading" the story so clearly told through Varon's cartoons and will especially relish the happy, dream-come-true ending.

*Clang! Clang! Beep! Beep!: Listen to the City* by Robert Burleigh, Beppe Giacobbe (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $14.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Preschool. 0. 1416940529




A day in the life of a young boy living in a big city goes full circle from the opening spread showing him sleeping (large ZZZs rising from his head) right before the alarm clock TING-A-LINGs to him sleeping in the deep purple of the night (the same large ZZZs appearing). Sandwiched in between is a cacophony of city sounds and activity that the boy hears and sees throughout the day going to and from school and everywhere in between. The brief rhyming verses make the book a strong read aloud choice; children will want to join in on the onomatopoetic sounds in bold letters on each page. The digitally-created, geometric graphic art in strong colors will even give rural children a sense of the big city bustle.

*Duck & Goose Find a Pumpkin* by Tad Hills.
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. Unpaged. $6.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 037585813X




In the newest Duck & Goose book, autumn surrounds these endearing characters as they hunt for a pumpkin. Duck and Goose look in a log, in a leaf pile, up a tree, under water, and on top of a stump in a carefully described search for the pumpkin. The simplicity of their conversation is perfect for young children developing language and an understanding of positional words. Tad Hills' illustrations tenderly depict the colors and warmth of the fall and compliment this seasonal story.

*Firefighter Ted* by Pascal Lemaitre, Andrea Beaty.
Margaret K. McElderry Books. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 1416928219




Using his powerful imagination, Ted the bear steps up to save his family and friends, even when they don't need saving. Smelling burning toast, he saves mom with a homemade fire extinguisher. Ted goes on to help kittens, puppies, the principal, and the school with his unique brand of firefighting. Simple, child-like illustrations add a light-hearted touch to the situations Ted encounters. This amusing book can prompt discussions about fire safety while celebrating the imagination of children.

*For Just One Day* by Laura Leuck, Marc Boutavant (Illustrator).
Chronicle Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0811856100




This book is a good balance between dreams and reality, with words and pictures collaborating seamlessly to elaborate and satisfy children's unrestrained imaginations. Each imaginary thought of being an animal is accompanied by illustrations where unfinished lines in the previous spread always reveal some hint of what the animal will be when readers turn the page. A small mirror attached to the last opening is an ingenious design that invites readers to interact with the book by making their own reflections part of the somewhat predictable ending. The animal patterns on the endpapers echo the theme.

*Hello Baby!* by Mem Fox, Steve Jenkins (Illustrator).
Beach Lane Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Science. Preschool. 0. 1416985131




"Hello, baby! Who are you?" Each page answers the question with a rhyming possibility of an African baby animal, including a lion, warthog and zebra. Each intriguing, cut-paper animal boldly occupies the white space of the page. Owl's "wicked wink" is squarely directed at anyone who dares to look! Young children will love the surprise of who the treasured baby really is. The book is one that begs to be read aloud and is sure to fascinate with each turn of the page.

*Hurry Up and Slow Down* by Layn Marlow.
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Preschool. Europe (Mediteranian). 0823421783




Based on the famous story of the Hare and Tortoise, this version is actually quite different in that it doesn't emphasize the competition between the two but how they live harmoniously together. From the very beginning Tortoise does most things in everyday life slowly, contrasting with the fast-acting Hare. In the end of the story, Tortoise reads a bedtime story to Hare, providing a surprising twist to the original fable. The softly colored illustrations of the happy pair are perfect for what will be a popular read aloud for young children right before they go to sleep.

*Hush, Baby Ghostling* by Andrea Beaty, Pascal Lemaitre (Illustrator).
Margaret K. McElderry Books. 2009. Unpaged. $14.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 1416925457




A ghostly version of a bedtime story and lulling scene, this book will be interesting to readers because of the ghost mother and a baby ghostling's perspectives. Reversing human children's common fears of the night, darkness, goblins and monsters, the baby ghostling fears exactly the opposite – the day, light, and human children. Even the comforting, skeleton doll might scare a human child but comforts the baby ghostling! What remains the same between the ghost and human child-parent relationships is a sense of security and the love and care a child receives from his/her mother. The ghost figures in this book are adorable, which would be less scary for young readers. There's a shift of color between night and day – purple for the night and pink for the day - giving strong visual cues for the transition of scenes.

*Llama Llama Misses Mama* by Anna Dewdney.
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0670061980




The creator of the adored **Llama Llama Red Pajama** book has created a third Llama Llama book. In the latest tale, Llama is headed off for his first day of preschool. Dewdney's short phrases carefully address the ups and downs of the big occassion. From the exciting new toys and friends to the loneliness of missing his mama to the thrill of pickup time, this book captures the vast array of emotions typical of this experience. The illustrations compliment the story by capturing the feelings and commotion of a preschool day. This is a wonderful story for any preschooler, especially one about to experience a first day.

*Mama, Will It Snow Tonight?* by Nancy White Carlstrom, Paul Tong (Illustrator).
Boyds Mills Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Informational Concept. Preschool. 0. 1590785622



Three sets of mother and children pairs, fox, hare, and human, ponder the same question: Will it snow? As each mother replies, the illustrations depict the end-of-autumn conditions that prompt the question: gray skies, falling leaves, mittens on hands. Each pair is ready for the change in season, and at last, it does, indeed, snow.

*Me with You* by Kristy Dempsey, Christopher Denise (Illustrator).
Philomel Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0399250174




The warm and caring relationship between a grandfather and a granddaughter makes this a perfect story for young children. The simple but touching rhyming text may remind children of their own times spent with loving grandparents. At the end of the story, the child takes a long, more adult view of life: "And though I'll find new ways of being me my whole life through, my favorite me will always be…when I am me with you." The pastel and watercolor illustrations create a warm ambiance that echoes the theme of the mutual love between grandparents and grandchildren.

*Moon Rabbit* by Natalie Russell.
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0670011703



Little Rabbit liked her city, with her favorite café and many things to see and do. Then she met Brown Rabbit. Music brought them together. But Brown Rabbit lives in a park outside of the city. Can their friendship last? **Moon Rabbit** is a simple and quiet story enhanced by Natalie Russell's charming prints.

*My Little Red Fire Truck* by Stephen T. Johnson.
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $19.99. Informational Social Studies. Preschool. 0. 1416925228




Just as he has done in his previous engaging books about a taxi and a tool box, Johnson introduces young children to what needs to be done to keep a fire truck ready to do its important work. Children will love manipulating the realistic, heavy cardbook, pop-out parts such as the pump for filling the tank with diesel and the tire pressure guage. A clock in the lower right shows the passage of time, since each of the ten "most important tasks" must take only 3 minutes. Children will spend many happy minutes - far more than 30! - reading and playing with this book.

*Night-Night, Little Pookie* by Sandra Boynton.
Random House. 2009. 15 pages. $5.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0375854096




Sandra Boynton's latest Pookie story addresses bedtime with an understanding for the capabilities of young children and the simplicity of routine. Little Pookie chooses his own pajamas, brushes his teeth, and heads to bed. Colorful and comical illustrations are paired with playful and loving language in classic Boynton style. This is a calming and empowering story for parents to read to their youngest children before bed.

*Ocean's Child* by Trish Holland, Christine Ford, David Diaz (Illustrator).
Golden Books. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Poetry. Preschool. Inuit. 0375847529



This is a gentle lullaby that repeatedly accentuates the caring and loving relationships between a mother and her child. An expectant Eskimo mother paddles through the sea with her child and encounters various mother and baby animal pairs, such as otters, walruses, dolphins, and whales. Maternal love is strongly emphasized throughout. The exquisite, soft-colored illustrations create a lulling atmosphere that corresponds well with the lullaby rhythm. The whirling patterns of sea waves sparkle here and there in the book, giving the illustrations a somehow mysterious tone that echoes the poetic text.

*Puffling* by Margaret Wild, Julie Vivas (Illustrator).
Feiwel & Friends. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0312565704




This coming-of-age story provides a sketch of puffins' life cycle along with its focus on parent-child relationships in general. The puffin family – Big Stripy Beak, Long Black Feather, and Puffling - shows the changes in relationships as children grow up, socialize, and even become parents themselves and understand how difficult raising children can be. Vivas's engaging pastel drawings focus on the loving parents and their beloved child as they prepare him to successfully face the dangers that await in the world. Warm and cool colors are used alternatively to indicate changes of mood. For example, the warm color tones of brown and orange are used when Puffling is young and safely in the burrow; later the tones turn to cool blues and greens when Puffling leaves the nest and joins puffin society.

*Shape by Shape* by Suse MacDonald.
Little Simon. 2009. Unpaged. $14.99. Informational Concept. Preschool. 0. 1416971475




Two small black circles peer from the center of a bright yellow page. "Do you know who I am?" With each turn of the page, more clues are given and more shapes - triangles, crescents, diamonds - are added until the familiar creature is triumphantly revealed on the final tri-fold spread. The boldly colored shapes of MacDonald's clever guessing game appear on both endpapers, so young readers can consider and reconsider how they were used to create her surprise. They will probably be inspired to construct their own creatures using her shapes as well.

*Surprise Soup* by Mary Ann Rodman, G. Brian Karas (Illustrator).
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 067006274X




This story focuses on the sometimes competitive relationships of older and younger siblings. After some humorous blunders, Kevie, previously the youngest but "promoted" to middle brother after his newborn

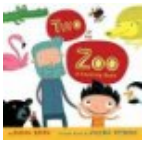
brother Julian arrives, proves that he knows no less than his older brother Josh does by helping make a surprisingly delicious pot of soup. Kevie is a voice for middle children who are often struggling under the dominance and taunts of their older siblings. The many sounds accompanying the soup cooking make this a great book to read aloud. Karas portrays the bear family and the reassuring domestic scene well with his heavily layered collages. The book will resonate most for young children learning to deal with their own complicated sibling relationships.

*The Odd Egg* by Emily Gravett.
Simon & Schuster. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 1416968725



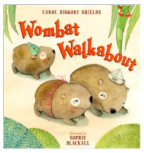
Duck peers underneath his leg for an egg that isn't there. Why do all the other birds have an egg? Luckily, he finds an egg much larger than he is, "the most beautiful egg in the whole world" and the fun begins. On progressively bigger pages, each baby bird hatches while duck waits and waits, drawing out the anticipation of what will hatch from his egg. The surprise baby who follows the waddling duck on the final endpages will have young readers laughing out loud. Another clever addition to Gravitt's entertaining repertoire.

*Two at the Zoo: A Counting Book* by Danna Smith, Valeria Petrone (Illustrator).
Clarion Books. 2009. 32 pages. $16.00. Informational Concept. Preschool. 0. 054704982X



Teeming with animals, a popular favorite among young children, this book feeds right into their enthusiasm. Danna Smith's language is full of simple rhymes and quick phrases that describe the excitement of a zoo trip. Valeria Petrone's illustrations capture the different emotions of the young zoo-goer as he delights, scrutinizes, and hides from the various animals. Your preschooler will enjoy naming and counting the different animals. A delightful read for any zoo lover.

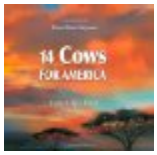
*Wombat Walkabout* by Carol Diggory Shields, Sophie Blackall (Illustrator).
Dutton Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Preschool. 0. 0525478655



A delightful reverse counting book that teaches Australian vocabulary as it tells the tale of six wombats who are apparently outwitted by a dingo. But, alas, the dingo took a dive and the wombats were saved for further walkabouts and a spot of tea. The rhyming text and sandy colored, engaging illustrations move the reader creatively to the happy ending. The book includes a short glossary with words of the Australian outback.

# Primary

*14 Cows for America* by Carmen Agra Deedy, Wilson Kimeli Naiyomah, Thomas Gonzalez (Illustrator). Peachtree. 2009. Unpaged. $17.95. Informational Social Studies. Primary. Africa (Eastern). 1561454907




Naiyomah is the character Kimeli in the story, a young Maasai man from Kenya studying in the United States who happened to be in New York City on September 11, 2001, and was devastated by the loss of life when the Twin Towers were destroyed. In simple language and richly colored realistic illustrations that capture the Kenyan countryside and its proud and compassionate people, the moving, true story of how sacred cows were presented to the American ambassador and his wife is told. Even young children can understand the emotions felt that day and appreciate the bonds shared with caring people on the other side of the world. This is a loving and very human tribute to the hope for world peace.

*A Book* by Mordicai Gerstein.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1596432519




The reader is introduced to a diminutive, pig-tailed girl on the jacket flap who ponders, "What's my story?" When the book is closed, it's blackest night and her family sleeps; when the book opens, the family awakens to begin a bright new day. As the girl wanders from page to page (her fire fighter mother warns, "Be careful crossing gutters.") in search of her special story, she explores all kinds of stories, some quite familiar, in which members of her family, including her pets, often star. At one point, she looks up and screams, "EEEEEK!" She quickly learns what a reader is from a knowledgeable goose who proceeds to lay a golden egg on the next page where her story resides. Gerstein cleverly uses the girl's day-long search to teach plenty about books and genres. The whole endeavor is one fun adventure. And the ending is just right!

*A Pinata in a Pine Tree: A Latino Twelve Days of Christmas* by Pat Mora, Magaly Morales (Illustrator).
Clarion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Poetry. Primary. Latino-American. 0618841989



Pat Mora has changed the traditional song "The Twelve Days of Christmas" by replacing the gifts such as the partridge in a pear tree with gifts representing Latino Christmas traditions. A young girl is given all kinds of wonderful foods and toys, including dos pastelitos (two small pastries) and seis trompos girando (six tops), but the best gift of all is her surprise amiga on the last double-page spread. The joyous illustrations in bright Latino-inspired colors capture the celebratory mood of the song. A glossary and Spanish pronunciation guide, author's and illustrator's notes, and the music are also included.

*An Apple Pie for Dinner* Carol Baicker-McKee (Illustrator), Susan VanHecke (Reteller).
M. Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Folk Literature. Primary. Great Britain. 0761454527




Based on the cumulative English folktale “The Apple Dumpling,” this retelling features Granny Smith (those reading aloud will love the word play) planning to make an apple pie but missing the key ingredient – apples. She brings a basket of plums and sets off, hoping to trade them for apples. Plums are traded for feathers, and feathers for flowers, and eventually Granny get what she wants. The baked clay and mixed-media illustrations create a merry and lighthearted atmosphere for reading aloud. The mixed-media gives the illustrations unique textures that make the story more vivid. An apple pie recipe, a note from the author, and information about the illustrations are helpful peripheral resources.

*Applesauce Season* by Eden Ross Lipson, Mordicai Gerstein (Illustrator).
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. 40 pages. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 1596432160



The story presents a cameo of a family’s tradition of making applesauce during the fall every year. The boy protagonist of the story is always so excited when applesauce season comes each year and relishes going shopping for various kinds of apples as well as making applesauce together with his mother and grandmother. This book is fascinating because it links such simple food, applesauce, with the warmth of a family. When the protagonist grows up, he passes on this family tradition to

his own daughter. The outlined watercolor illustrations and the casual drawing style surround readers with the comfortable feeling of family warmth. An applesauce recipe is included.

*Big George: How a Shy Boy Became President Washington* by Anne Rockwell, Matt Phelan (Illustrator).
Gulliver Books/Harcourt. 2009. 48 pages. $17.00. Biography/Memoir. Primary. 0. 0152165835



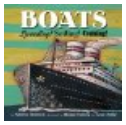

This is a thorough overview of George Washington's life and his marvelous feats in leading American soldiers to win the War of Independence, as well as his dutiful leadership as the first president of the United States. As a young, shy boy, Washington was versatile and brave. As he grew older and became a knowledgeable and even more courageous man, he devoted himself to the battlefield – first for the king but later for America's independence. His sublime personality and invincible courage are at the heart of the story. He didn't desire power but still became president because of his sense of duty. The text isn't intended to exaggerate or deify his position in American history. Instead, the narration is quite down-to-earth and documentary, faithfully presenting Washington's life. The pencil and watercolor illustrations capture Washington's powerful presence and resolution well, especially in the opening which depicts the intrepid Washington's heroic bearing on the battlefield.

*Black Beauty* Susan Jeffers (Illustrator), Sharon Lerner (Reteller).
Random House Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Primary. Great Britain. 037585892X




Retold from Anna Sewell's **Black Beauty**, originally published in 1877, the story of Black Beauty is presented in an abridged form in this picture book. The first-person narrative perspective is kept in this retelling, drawing readers closer to the heart of the horse protagonist. The plot is intense and fast paced, showing Black Beauty having many difficult encounters with different masters. The illustrations emphasize Black Beauty's expressive eyes, and most of the pictures are close-ups of Black Beauty and his other horse companions, which make the story's theme stand out. In addition, as Black Beauty finally finds his best, and also last, master, who promises to never sell him, the tone of the illustrations is brighter and more colorful, indicating the end of Black Beauty's hard toil; he will be taken good care of henceforth.

*Boats: Speeding! Sailing! Cruising!* by Patricia Hubbell, Sean Addy (Illustrator), Megan Halsey (Illustrator).
M. Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Informational Social Studies. Primary. 0. 0761455248




Patricia Hubbell has written an engaging book about watercraft, told with rhyming text and illustrations that are appealing and informative. The reader is introduced to a vast array of boats, and, in the process, learns the vocabulary of "speeding, sailing and cruising." This book encourages visioning and learning about many boats, from canoes and kayaks to battleships and submarines. "Toy boats sail in ponds and streams in your tub and in your dreams."

*Bridget Fidget and The Most Perfect Pet* by Joe Berger.
Dial Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0803734050




Black-haired and highly energetic Bridget Fidget has always wanted a pet – a real, live pet unicorn. A mysterious box delivered to her home arouses Bridget's curiosity. What pops out of the box is at first disappointing, but her parents unexpectedly provide the perfect pet. The comic-styled illustrations are light-hearted, and the illustrator's color technique highlights the protagonist on key pages.

*Bubble Trouble* by Margaret Mahy, Polly Dunbar (Illustrator).
Clarion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0547074212



Gently floating blue-green bubbles on the endpapers really don't foretell the madcap adventure that happens when Baby is carried away after his sister Mabel blows a giant, troublesome bubble that bobbles his way, lifts him up into the sky and out of the house. The ensuing chase involving Mabel, Mother, Tybal and his mother Sybil, and eventually even Canon Dapple and the whole chapel choir is rollicking good fun bolstered by the rhyming, alliterative text (that is at times as wavy as Baby's bubble floating in the breeze) and the madly scrambling characters all dressed in bright colors and distinctive patterns. Abel, "a rascal and a rebel...with nefarious intentions," does unintentionally save the day when

he pops a shocked Baby down to earth towards his horrified mother and others in the crowd who luckily know just how to save him from a horrible fate. The wonderful language, happy ending and light-hearted illustrations make this a book that will be relished by readers again and again. A great companion to other cumulative tales like **The Gingerbread Boy** or **Rachel Fister's Blister.**

*Bullies Never Win* by Margery Cuyler, Arthur Howard (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0689861877



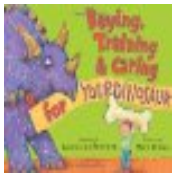

Jessica is a worrier having concerns about everything, but especially about bullying Brenda who always picks on her and makes fun of her at school. Jessica does have a difficult time coping with her situation until she finally guts it out, stands up to Brenda and lets her know "bullies never win." The story is written in a down-to-earth style that faithfully depicts bullying problems commonly seen in grade schools. The watercolor and felt pen illustrations give the characters a comic book look that exaggerates the tensions between the bully and the bullied.

*Button Up! Wrinkled Rhymes* by Alice Schertle, Petra Mathers (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 33 pages. $16.00. Poetry. Primary. 0. 0152050507




Wrinkled rhymes? Yes, because in these poems it is the clothing, wrinkled or not, that does the talking! Shoelaces declare, "We're hang loose laces and/we don't do bows!" An old t-shirt laments the fact that she's been designated a dust rag. Proud undies strut their stuff. There's plenty of pleasure, rhythm and rhyme for everyone in these clever paeans to kids' favorite garments. Mathers' light-hearted depictions of very appropriate animals for each clothing item certainly add to the fun.

*Buying, Training, and Caring for Your Dinosaur* by Laura Joy Rennert, Marc Brown (Illustrator).
Knopf Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0375836799



A detailed guide of how to select a perfect dino for yourself and how to take care of it is included in this imaginative story based on the author's childhood fantasy of having dinos as pets. The crayon drawings resemble children's art, a perfect match to the story. In the middle openings, each spread is titled with a different species of dinosaur, indicating habitual behaviors. The "helpful recommendations" on the back endpaper makes this book informative as well. This is a book that unleashes children's imaginations about dinosaurs!

*By the Light of the Halloween Moon* by Caroline Stutson, Kevin Hawkes (Illustrator).
M. Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0761455531




This is a compelling "cumulative Halloween story" featuring a young girl's toes and a range of different goblins and monsters. The text is rhymed, creating a rhythmic story perfect for reading aloud. Humor is peppered throughout the fast-paced tale; readers' funny bones will be tickled when reading about how each character attempts to eat the girl's toes and dramatically and hilariously fails. The girl finally smacks the sprite with her violin, which is a funny twist leading to a warm ending with everyone dancing in the silvery moonlight of Halloween night. The somber hues of the illustrations' backgrounds add to the spooky Halloween atmosphere, though almost every character is highlighted by some bright and warm colors that lessen the dread. The Gothic font of the title on the cover also corresponds well with the Halloween theme of the story.

*Can You Make a Scary Face?* by Jan Thomas.
Beach Lane Books. 2009. 40 pages. $12.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416985816



It all starts with a green-skinned ladybug's statement that commands readers to stand up, and then imagination gets wilder and wilder. Eventually the story ends with the ladybug making a scary face at the giant frog, hence the book title. This colorful book would grab young readers' attention, especially because of the dramatic expressions of the ladybug. In addition, the font on each opening changes in size and color, highlighting various textual emphases in the story, thus making this book a good resource for younger children's word recognition practice.

*Come to the Fairies' Ball* by Jane Yolen, Gary Lippincott (Illustrator).
Wordsong. 2009. Unpaged. $17.95. Fantasy. Primary. Europe (Western). 1590784642



Similar to the Cinderella story, at the beginning of this story, an invitation to the ball is sent to all fairies. From the illustrations of fairies of all different sorts, readers can quickly tell that the ball is special. No human beings are invited! Although one fairy decides she can't go because of her shabby dress, she gets help and is able to attend after all. The tale ends with a surprising twist to these traditional story elements. Both the lilting text and the lush illustrations point out unusual facts about fairies: only fairies would have such elaborate costumes, including a "spider-web gown," or bizarre vehicles such as rabbits, turtles, dragonflies or snails. The artfully rhymed, descriptive text, with precisely chosen words, matches the illustrations' whimsical style.

*Cool Cat* by Nonny Hogrogian.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1596434295




The protagonist of this wordless story is a black cat who uses his paints and collaborates with other small animals to artistically transform the bleak wasteland at the beginning of the story into beautiful scenery by the end. The paint brushes of the black cat seem to be magical, for when the beautiful landscape is completed, it comes to life. The mallard actually swims in the painted pond; the black cat smells the roses, indicating that all the things painted on the wall and the ground of the wasteland become real. In addition, there is an interesting contrast between the endpapers at the front and in the back: the bleak and deserted scenes of the vacant lot in the former become a vibrant and colorful landscape in the latter. Magic has truly transformed the scene!

*Creature abc* by Andrew Zuckerman.
Chronicle Books. 2009. Unpaged. $19.99. Informational Concept. Primary. 0. 0811869784




Bb is for bear, a wistful bear staring off camera. Turn the page, and he seems to be waving at the reader. Jj is for jackrabbit, who seemingly jumps from one page onto the next. Kangaroo and lion stare at each other across the white space of their two facing pages; turn the page and hope that kangaroo has escaped! Awe-inspiring photos from sometimes unusual perspectives (beginning with zebra-striped end papers) will keep readers turning the page, seeing what they'll discover next about the alphabet and some amazing creatures. The glossary includes another photo of each along with a line or two of fascinating information that could lead to further research.

*Dinosaur Tamer* by Carol Greathouse, John Shroades (Illustrator).
Dutton Juvenile. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0525478663



The author bases this cowboy-themed story on her children's enthusiasm for dinosaurs. As a famous dinosaur tamer, Rocky faces the greatest challenge he's ever met – a T-Rex! The T-Rex becomes his good companion and best ride, and together they carry on with their future adventures across the U.S. This story would be appealing to lots of young dinosaur fans. The geographical background of the Rocky Mountains and the three national parks is a good match with the story and is faithfully presented in the computer-graphic illustrations.

*Dinosaurs Roar, Butterflies Soar!* by Bob Barner.
Chronicle Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Science. Primary. 0. 0811856631



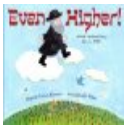
Dinosaur books are a must for primary grade classrooms. Barner's picture book offers a new twist on a classic science subject for young readers by focusing on the small winged creatures that coexisted—and outlasted—the roaming giants that still captivate children and adults alike. With parallel texts offering light and lyrical prose along with more substantial scientific information about dinosaurs, early butterflies, and the plant life that connected them, the book welcomes readers exhibiting various levels of engagement with the subject. A timeline and "extra facts" page extend the literacy experience. Citrus-colored collage illustrations, with carefully selected accents of texture, add tangible appeal to an already alluring topic. Like butterflies to nectar, students will flutter excitedly to **Dinosaurs Roar, Butterflies Soar**!

*Duck! Rabbit!* by Amy Krouse Rosenthal, Tom Lichtenheld (Illustrator).
Chronicle Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Concept. Primary. 0. 0811868656




Quick! Look at the cover and tell me what you see. A duck? A rabbit? Think two faces or a vase, and you'll know there's no correct answer, though the two, unillustrated narrators argue the point throughout this clever book with its boldly outlined 'rabbitduck' doing whatever it is that rabbits - or ducks - do. The book has to be read aloud, preferably with two voices, and then watch the discussion begin. The ending really isn't one, only reinforcing the insights that can be gleaned about point of view from this clever book. For more visual play, check out the zebra on the back cover.

*Even Higher! A Rosh Hashanah Story* by I. L. Peretz, Jill Weber (Illustrator), Eric A. Kimmel (Reteller).
Holiday House. 2009. 24 pages. $16.95. Folk Literature. Primary. Europe (Eastern). 0823420205




This book is a light-hearted adaptation of a Jewish tale about Rosh Hashanah and the disappearing rabbi of Nemirov. People in the village believe that the rabbi goes to heaven each year at this time and pleads to God to forgive their sins. One villager discovers instead that the rabbi goes out to chop wood for an old and sickly woman. One difference between this adaptation and the traditional tale is that the old woman dances with the rabbi to the melody of a Ukrainian drinking song, which is based on the reteller's childhood memory of his grandmother teaching him how to dance. The central theme of the tale is that ordinary kindness is greater than any kind of miracle. Those familiar with the holiday and the Yiddish folk style will appreciate the tale the most.

*Finding Susie* by Sandra Day O'Connor, Tom Pohrt (Illustrator).
Knopf Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary. 0. 0375841032



The central message of this story is that it's best for wild animals to live in their natural habitat, even though it's also important for a young girl to have a pet. Sandra lived on a ranch as a child and longed to keep pets. Her parents allowed her to take care of several different kinds of wild animals, ranging from a tortoise, to a rabbit, an injured coyote, and a deserted bobcat. Through taking care of these wild animals, Sandra gradually realized that wild animals live best in the wilderness, and through the help of a wise grocer, finally found a perfect pet, a fluffy white dog named Susie. The watercolor illustrations capture the desert Southwest and its inhabitants. Even the wild animals' grudging expressions while being kept by Sandra are depicted well. The watercolor paintings also create a warm atmosphere for the endearing story. In addition, the endpapers are designed with Sandra's childhood photos with the wild animals she lived with, indicating that this is an autobiographical story from author Sandra Day O'Connor's childhood.

*First Pooch: The Obamas Pick a Pet* by Carole Boston Weatherford, Amy Bates (Illustrator).
Marshall Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Social Studies. Primary. African-American. 0761456368




After their father, now the president, promised them a dog for being so helpful and patient during his long campaign, Malia and Sasha spent a great deal of time deciding on the perfect pet, a dog as noble as Washington's foxhounds and as friendly as Clinton's Buddy. Weatherford tells the straightforward story of how Bo was thoughtfully selected and named while Bates' expressive illustrations show all the possibilities leading to the happy addition to the family. Promise kept!

*Froggy's Best Babysitter* by Jonathan London, Frank Remkiewicz (Illustrator).
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0670011762



Froggy lovers are in luck. London and Remkiewicz have teamed up again to create another laugh-out-loud Froggy story. With his parents off for a night to themselves, Froggy and his sister are left with a new babysitter. Froggy quickly delves into the typical babysitter-testing shenanigans. Children will guffaw as Froggy attempts to cook, talk the sitter into extra dessert, and wiggle out of bath time. Once again Froggy's creators capture a typical childhood experience and explore it with a humorous flourish.

*Funny Farm* by Mark Teague.
Orchard Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 043991499X




This is an interesting story about Edward, a city-slicker dog, visiting his relatives' farm and his many hilarious attempts to help out with the farm chores. For instance, Edward helps to make maple syrup but ends up getting his paw stuck in a bucket or learns how to knit but can only produce a ragged piece of woven fabric. Edward's clumsiness and his hosts' tolerance are depicted in a very humorous way. The elaborate, colorful oil paintings are ludicrous and definitely add to the fun.

*Goldilocks* by Ruth Sanderson.
Little, Brown. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Folk Literature. Primary. Great Britain. 0316778850




This is an interesting retelling of the familiar folk tale **Goldilocks and the Three Bears**. While the early story elements will be familiar, the tale changes direction, offering an unexpected ending. In this version, Momma Bear makes Goldilocks make up the beds and help repair Baby Bear's chair. She also bakes delicious blueberry muffins, using the blueberries contributed by Goldilocks, to replace their missing bowls of porridge. A surprising twist to the usual plot! The illustrations with the characters' embroidered costumes and long ago cottage setting give readers a sense of time and place and also emphasize Momma Bear's stern yet warm spirit and Goldilocks' remorse.

*Goldilocks and the Three Bears* by Gennady Spirin.
M. Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Folk Literature. Primary. Great Britain. 0761455965



This version of the old British folk tale is retold in a simple manner but is illustrated in a far more flamboyant style, giving it a Renaissance zest. The four characters appear in Renaissance costumes; the three bears dwell in a Tudor cottage; and ornate typeface as well as the decorative borders sparkle on each page. Different from most of the cuddly and fluffy bear family images in the Goldilocks tale picture books, the bears have sharp and scary teeth and claws. Their beastly images and facial expressions clearly remind readers that they are wild animals! The bear family's irritated, threatening gestures contrast with Goldilocks' gleeful and naughty facial expressions at the end of the story. The abrupt ending shows the bear family bidding goodbye to Goldilocks.

*Green Wilma: Frog in Space* by Tedd Arnold.
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Science Fiction. Primary. 0. 0803726988



Poor Wilma finds herself aboard a spaceship with alien beings that resemble her a lot--except that they're blue instead of green. When her captors discover that they've mistaken Wilma for their very own "Blooger," they make a hasty return to Earth to make an exchange. The rhyming text and vivid illustrations will appeal to young readers who enjoy a goofy romp.

*Groundhog Weather School* by Joan Holub, Kristin Sorra (Illustrator).
Putnam. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0399246592




Professor Groundhog started a Groundhog Weather School and recruited groundhog students (although a skunk, who claimed himself a "foreign exchange student", was also admitted) to help him predict the coming of spring all over North America. In a humorous way, this book presents knowledge about nature to young readers via anthropomorphized groundhog perspectives. A variety of illustrative layouts is deployed – some look like newspaper columns and documentary profiles, whereas others range from comic strips to imaginary groundhog classes. Even the endpapers are ingeniously designed with groundhog burrows' construction blueprints.

*Grumpy Grandpa* by Heather Henson, Ross MacDonald (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 1416908110




Grandpa seems kind of scary. He doesn't laugh, he has hair in places that shouldn't have hair, and the whole house has to stay quiet while he naps. Every day he disappears for a while. One day, though, things are different. Grandpa and grandson disappear together to go fishing. They sit still for a long time; they fall in the water together; they laugh together; and they remember and learn that all people

were little once. With the help of colorful watercolor illustrations, this book relates a vital story of the growing understanding between generations.

*Guess Again!* by Mac Barnett, Adam Rex (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Poetry. Primary. 0. 1416955666



Several riddles with deceptive answers are hinted at by misleading quatrains and comic illustrations. This interesting picture book gives young readers off-the-wall opportunities to use their abilities to make good guesses. The text and the illustrations play with readers' natural assumptions to answer a certain way when given clues, but on the next opening there's always an unexpected answer that subverts readers' previous guesses. When readers finally generalize some rules to make what they think are good guesses, they are surprised again by an even more unexpected answer. The illustrations work together well with the text, presenting more misleading visual details to fool the audience. Even the smartest readers probably won't get the answers to the riddles right because the whole book is so nonsensical, but that is exactly what makes it so much fun!

*Here Comes Jack Frost* by Kazuno Kohara.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. Unpaged. $12.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1596434422




A young boy who is sure he hates winter sulks in a brown chair in his gray house. Swirling patterns appear on his window on a very cold morning, and his dull world turns vivid blue and bright white when he meets the lively Jack Frost. The inevitable ending to their winter adventures looks ahead to future encounters. End papers in varying shades of blue are sprinkled with lovely snowflakes, inviting everyone to enjoy the season.

*Homegrown House* by Janet S. Wong, E.B. Lewis (Illustrator).
Margaret K. McElderry Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0689847181



What makes a house a home...and a homegrown one at that? Grandmom's lived in just two houses in her 65 years, the perfect number from her granddaughter's point of view. "I'm eight/ and already I've lived in three." As her parents move and plot about their perfect house, the little girl catalogues all that makes Grandmom's so special. The realistic watercolor illustrations let the reader explore these places and the little girl's emotions so well. The end papers look just like the kind of wallpaper a Grandmom would choose for her well-loved kitchen.

*Hook* by Ed Young.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. Unpaged. $17.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1596433639



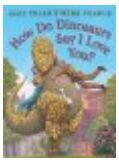

While others have written more elaborate stories about eggs being hatched by unlikely mothers, Young's poetic, minimal text simply begins, "An abandoned egg." Pages covered in the bold sienna of the desert Southwest, sometimes smeared with a dark brooding sky, serve as the backdrop for Hook's struggle to fly while he's encouraged by his adoptive mother hen, his chick siblings and a young, Native American boy. Sweeping cobalt blue skies and deep canyons beckon the young eagle, who soars high above at the end into a bright, white sky as he "wasn't meant for earth." While Young's illustrations are as minimal in detail as his text, they give rich life to each character.

*Horace and Morris Say Cheese (Which Makes Dolores Sneeze!)* by James Howe, Amy Walrod (Illustrator).
Ginee Seo Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0689839405



Dolores has been enjoying eating cheese just as all her other mouse friends do, until one day she suddenly finds that she's allergic to cheese! Such a bolt from the blue brings a dramatic change to her life – no more cheese with the cheese festival coming. Fortunately, Dolores is very resourceful and adapts to a variety of other kinds of food – even enjoying them more than cheese! Entertaining, anthropomorphized mouse characters illustrate an allergy problem faced by some children. This encouraging story provides a good example of how allergic children can adapt to their new eating restrictions.

*How Do Dinosaurs Say I Love You?* by Jane Yolen, Mark Teague (Illustrator).
Blue Sky Press. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0545143144



The rhyming story makes an interesting and comic analogy between dinosaurs and children, and both kids and parents who read this book would agree that there's indeed something the two share in common! The naughty dinosaurs display childish mischief throughout the story. Children who are big fans of dinosaurs will find the endpapers a good resource listing the 10 dinosaurs in the book with their names. The loving parent-child relationship is repeated in each scene of the book; no matter how mischievous and troublesome the dinosaur child is, the parents always love them without any conditions. The pastel and oil illustrations in vibrant colors create a jolly and loving atmosphere for the book.

*I Will Be Especially Very Careful* by Lauren Child.
Dial Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0803733798



Another interesting book in the Charlie and Lola series is about friendship that is put to the test. When Lotta wears a new coat, a white and fluffy pretty coat that is an extra-special gift from her granny, envious Lola suggests swapping her new handbag for Lotta's coat and promises to be very careful with it. Subsequently, Lola forgets the coat in the library. Fortunately, the coat is eventually retrieved by another classmate as Lola confesses to Lotta that she lost her coat. Honesty is always the best policy is the important lesson learned by Lola. The illustrations are created by collages of various media, and the exquisite texture of Lotta's coat emphasizes just how precious it is. Pink endpapers with bow tie prints are appropriately girly.

*If I Were A Jungle Animal* by Amanda Ellery, Tom Ellery.
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $15.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416937781




This is a story for any youngster standing in the outfield on the long hot summer afternoons of little league baseball games. While he waits for the ball to come to the outfield, understandably, this young baseball player's imagination roams. The expressive and colorful illustrations boldly jump off the page to capture the lively animals in this ball player's mind. He creatively conjures up jungle animals he could be . . . a lion, a monkey, a giraffe . . . only to encounter the downsides of each exciting option. He finds himself escaping cheetahs, enduring trees filled with chatty birds, and crocodile attacks. Fortunately, he emerges from his imaginary world just in time to catch the ball hurtling towards him!

*It's Picture Day Today!* by Megan McDonald, Katherine Tillotson (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416924345




It's picture day today at the Cartoon School, and buttons, feathers, sequins, and all other kinds of knickknacks hurry to school to pose for artwork and be photographed by their teacher. Everyone is there except Glue, who's running late and is the key to putting the whole class together. Simple sentences narrate the story in a straightforward way, while the collage illustrations, as well as the font that varies in size, add vivacity to the book. The pictures employ good use of contrasting colors to make the subjects stand out in each spread. This book would help young readers build up their art lexicon and spur their interest in creating their own art.

*Jeremy Draws a Monster* by Peter McCarty.
Henry Holt & Company. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0805069348




This is a seemingly simple story of a young boy who is imaginative and creates a big blue monster and the many other items it demands using his fancy pen (think about Harold and his purple crayon). The story has a connotative meaning showing that this boy, like other children, has problems fitting in. At the beginning of the story, the text mentions that the boy has his own room and never goes out to play with other children. The illustration shows the lonely boy standing in front of a window, watching other children play. Fortunately, having gone through the troubles caused by the big blue monster, the boy finally decides to step out from his lonely imagination and embrace reality. By the end of the story, he has been invited to join the group of children to play ball, and he opens up his heart and attempts to fit into the group. The simplicity of words and the openness of the illustrations allow ample space for the smooth flowing, imaginative story.

*Just Like Baby* by Juanita Havill, Christine Davenier (Illustrator).
Chronicle Books. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0811850269




All of the relatives had opinions regarding the future of Baby Ellen, but they were all silenced by her "listen-to-me-I'm-a-baby" squall. At that point they had to agree that for now Baby Ellen would do just what she pleased. Davenier's amusing ink and watercolor illustrations are perfect for this book that will surely be enjoyed by families who have welcomed a new baby into their household. The author and illustrator previously collaborated on **I Heard It from Alice Zucchini**.

*Ladybug Girl and Bumblebee* by David Soman, Jacky Davis (Illustrator).
Dial Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0803733399




Peer interactions and conflicts are truly depicted in this story of the friendships of young children. Lulu, as superhero "Ladybug Girl," is dressed in a red tutu and polka dots. She creates her own role-playing game, involving her friend Sam as “Bumblebee Boy” and the other two girls as “Butterfly Girl” and “Dragonfly Girl.” What is successful about this story is that the lessons taught about how friends should treat each other are a subtle part of the story. In addition, the comical yet realistic style of the illustrations also gives this book a light and friendly ambiance that echoes with the theme of children’s friendship well. One in a series of books about Lulu and her friends.

*Listen to the Wind: The Story of Dr. Greg and Three Cups of Tea* by Susan Roth, Greg Mortenson, Susan Roth (Illustrator).
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. 32 pages. $16.99. Informational Social Studies. Primary. Asia (Middle East). 0803730586



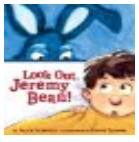
Greg Mortenson, author of **Three Cups of Tea**, has created a picture book version of his incredible experience of building schools in Pakistan for young children. Mortenson's words and actions demonstrate his inspiring kindness. Susan Roth's vibrant paper collages reflect colorful Pakistani garments and culture. In a time when Pakistan is considered dangerous or even insignificant by many, Mortenson brings the need for attention front and center and introduces young readers to the country's inhabitants.

*Long Shot: Never Too Small to Dream Big* by Chris Paul, Frank Morrison (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary. African-American. 1416950796




NBA All-Star Chris Paul’s uplifting story shows how he succeeds on the basketball court with hard practice and determination that makes up for his short stature. Beginning with his imagining himself passing to Michael Jordan, Chris Paul recounts his childhood experience of intensely preparing to try out for a local basketball team. He was given a wise piece of advice by his grandfather that lead him to his future success – practice, practice, and practice! Told in first person by the superstar player, this encouraging story would be appealing to children who are also keen on basketball. The pastel illustrations employ a down-to-earth palette and style that matches Paul's spirit.

*Look Out, Jeremy Bean!* by Alice Schertle, David Slonim (Illustrator).
Chronicle Books. 2009. 58 pages. $14.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. Multicultural. 0811856097




The three episodes in the life of young Jeremy Bean show that Schertle knows just the kind of problems that primary grade children encounter: What kind of collection would be interesting enough to share with his class? Would a dust bunny make a good pet? How could he be the only one to forget to wear something green for St. Patrick's Day? Luckily, Jeremy is one good problem solver whose antics will appeal to early readers. Comic black and white illustrations add to the humor.

*Looking for Luna* by Tim Myers, Mike Reed (Illustrator).
Marshall Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0761455647




In this comforting story, Luna is a grey tiger-striped cat who roams every night but always returns home every day. The rhyming story of the little girl’s and her father's search for her cat introduces readers to

many cats and their antics, but none of them are her missing cat! Luna's wanderlust is illustrated well in this story, as we sometimes only see her from behind as she heads off on her next solitary adventure. The lush neighborhood is filled with opportunities for cat exploration.

*Louie* by Will Hillenbrand.
Philomel Books. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary. Europe (Western). 0399247076



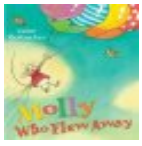

Based loosely on the childhood of Ludwig Bemelmans, the famous author of the picture book series about Madeline, this fantasy not only pays homage to the man and his work but also portrays the common experience of art-talented children who take a greatly different path compared to their peers. Louie the piglet's passion for art makes him an eccentric in school and leads to his being expelled. He encounters even more failure after dropping out of school. After so many struggles, Louie's art is finally appreciated by the public. Hillenbrand seems to see himself in Ludwig Bemelmans's childhood experience as well. The mixed media illustrations - acrylic paintings, pencil and watercolor drawings - give the book an artistically exuberant look that complements the theme. Artistic children will smile from the bottom of their hearts when reading this book.

*Lousy Rotten Stinkin' Grapes* by Margie Palatini, Barry Moser (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Folk Literature. Primary. 0. 0689802463




Aesop's "The Fox and the Grapes" was never as hilarious as this version of the fable, another in a highly entertaining series of retellings by the author and illustrator. Tantilizing, succulent, deep purple grapes hang just out of Fox's reach near the top of the page. He repeatedly boasts to one animal after another about how sly and clever and smart he is, even though each of his preposterous plans for obtaining the grapes fails. Palatini's Fox says the funniest things to his companions, calling Beaver "my dentally challenged chum." What a wonderful book to read aloud, as long as children can see all the animal's droll faces as they pile one on top of the other and eventually watch Fox strut off in a huff as they devour the grapes.

*Molly Who Flew Away* by Valeri Gorbachev.
Philomel Books. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0399252118




In this warm story about friendship, the big fair coming to town excites Molly and her good friends. Enjoying their companionship, Molly decides to buy a colored balloon for each of them. But she is lifted up into the sky unexpectedly. The fact that Molly's finally rescued by her friends is a metaphor exalting the warmth of friends' support. Simple sentences along with watercolor and pencil illustrations create a sincere atmosphere well suited to the story's theme.

*Money Madness* by David A. Adler, Edward Miller (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Informational Math. Primary. 0. 0823414744



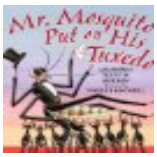

What young child can resist a book about money, especially when there are photos of real money from around the world interspersed with humorous, stylized illustrations of Uncle Sam using the various forms of money discussed? This breezy introduction to money and its origins successfully explores concepts such as the barter system, why paper money has value and the fluctuating value of the dollar in terms that young children can understand. If there's a classroom store with play money, this book belongs on the shelf.

*Moon Over the Mountain* by Keith Polette, Michael Kress-Russick (Illustrator).
Raven Tree Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Folk Literature. Primary. Hispanic. 1934960071



This is a traditional Asian tale retold with an American Southwest setting. The protagonist, Agipito, was a hardworking stonecutter who had been very dissatisfied cutting stones day after day. Longing for a different and more satisfactory life, Agipito made several requests to the Spirit of the Desert and, never happy, was granted his wish to be a rich merchant, the sun, a dust storm, a mountain, and finally, a coyote. The digitally created illustrations place this tale in the American Southwest by incorporating details of the tawny-colored desert setting, the craggy protagonist in miner's clothing, and the symbolic representation of coyote.

*Mr. Mosquito Put on His Tuxedo* by Barbara Olenyik Morrow, Ponder Goembel (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0823420728



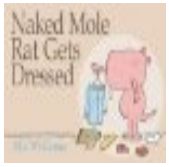

A variety of insects - dragonflies, ladybugs, moths, lice, and crickets - are invited to the Queen Bee's fancy ball, but it's Mr. Mosquito who turns out to be a hero when he and his friends save everyone's lives when they're threatened by a stomping bear. The clever, rhyming text incorporates humorous descriptions of the habitual behaviors of different insects, such as the lice's penchant for combs, bedbugs' love for pillows, and Mr. Mosquito's craving for blood. Much of the story is told through detailed, cartoon-styled illustrations that show the surprise setting of the ball at the end of the book. Young bug enthusiasts will enjoy hearing the book read aloud.

*My Brother Bert* by Ted Hughes, Tracey Campbell Pearson (Illustrator).
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Poetry. Primary. 0. 0374399824




As a younger sister catalogues all the exotic animals her brother Bert owns when she allows them all out of her brother's room while he's away, the eventual wild rumpus involving her and every animal imaginable, from the tiny mouse to the gigantic gorilla, is exuberantly illustrated. The pangolins peering out from behind the wallpaper on the endpapers only begin to hint at the fun that's in store for young readers. Hughes's rhymes are quite clever and his ideas so entertaining that children will want to hear the book read aloud over and over again. Each time, they'll discover something new happening in the lively illustrations.

*Naked Mole Rat Gets Dressed* by Mo Willems.
Hyperion Books for Children. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 142311437X




"NAKED MOLE RATS DON'T WEAR CLOTHES!" is what poor Wilbur, who bucks the trend and loves being nattily dressed, hears from all of his very pink, totally naked friends. Fortunately for all of them, Grand-pah is very wise and comes up with a perfect, very tolerant solution to the problem. This is another sure-fire, hilarious book by Willems that also has a powerful message to deliver. What young child won't be laughing out loud after seeing a procession of naked creatures, especially if one who is usually dressed, but desperately wants to fit in, arrives only in socks? Willem's fans will love the character on the t-shirt Wilbur sells to a friend on the last page. "Why not?" indeed!

*One Fine Trade* Will Hillenbrand (Illustrator), Bobbi Miller (Reteller).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Folk Literature. Primary. 0. 0823418367




Georgy Piney Woods's daughter, Georgianne, is going to get married and so is in urgent need of a beautiful wedding dress. Her loving father, an expert peddler, barters their skinny horse for a fat brown cow, then trades the cow for an old hound dog, and so on. The cumulative pattern of bartering eventually leads to his daughter's wedding dress. The story is inspired by a Southern folk song with the special vernacular language of the region. The comical pencil and watercolor illustrations add more fun to the story and enhance the characters' personalities.

*One World, One Day* by Barbara Kerley.
National Geographic Society. 2009. 46 pages. $17.95. Informational Social Studies. Primary. Multicultural. 1426304617




Every child should read this beautiful story. Stunning photographs capture the simple moments of children throughout the world as they get up, have breakfast, and go about a typical day. This book is a true celebration of diversity. Through pictures and simple words, readers are struck by the similarity of each child's day despite the vast differences between homes and cultures. Kerley closes the story with the thought that "around the world kids dream of tomorrow and the possibilities of just one day." The sentiment describes the overall warmth and optimism of this wonderful book.

*Otis* by Loren Long.
Philomel Books. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0399252487



The nostalgic story and illustration style harken back to earlier children's favorites like **Mike Mulligan and his Steam Shovel**. A personified, small red tractor saves the day when the big yellow tractor with angry eyes has no luck. The gray background lets the characters, including the chocolate brown calf who needs saving, in this warm-hearted story stand out. The little hero's "Putt puff puttedy chuff" is a soothing sound to the calf, the chickens and readers alike.

*Patricia Von Pleasantsquirrel* by James Proimos.
Dial Books. 2009. 56 pages. $15.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0803730667



Patricia is so bored by her family and her present ordinary, not-a-bit royal life that she believes herself to have an unrecognized, innate princessdom. Therefore, she decides to venture to a far away kingdom of hippos where she is crowned their princess. Being a princess for too long can be boring as well, and so there comes a day when Patricia finally decides to return to her plebeian life – and finds that being herself is still the best! The author was inspired by Maurice Sendak's **Where the Wild Things Are**. Patricia actually is reading the book when she's inspired to embark on her quest. The outlined comic-style illustrations, even with their limited palette, present Patricia's home-away-from-home adventure in a vivid way.

*Pearl and Wagner: One Funny Day* by Kate McMullan, R.W. Alley (Illustrator).
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $14.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0803730853



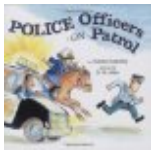
Pearl and Wagner are back again in another story of what it means to be a friend. In this case, Wagner doesn't think it's very funny that's he's constantly being fooled by everyone's April Fools jokes, including those by his best friend Pearl, his teacher, the librarian and even the cafeteria server who asks, "How about some fish-eye stew?" In a very satisfying ending, Wagner finally gets his chance to fool everyone, and he "laughs himself silly," much to the chagrin of all involved. Alley's comic illustrations of the menagerie of animal characters perfectly represent emotions and the humorous action. Observant readers will notice that Henry, who is actually the only one who's excited to read that bug juice will be served in the cafeteria, is a frog. A Level 2, Easy-to-Read book.

*Pigs Make Me Sneeze!* by Mo Willems.
Hyperion Books for Children. 2009. Unpaged. $8.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1423114116



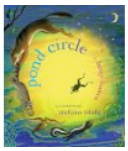
In the latest hilarious addition to the "Elephant and Piggie" series, Elephant repeatedly sneezes and almost aaaaachoooos Piggie right off the page. His dramatic conclusion? "What if pigs make me sneeze?" Happily, he discovers from Doctor Cat that this is not the case. By the end of the book, poor Piggie isn't quite as happy with Elephant's news! Simple comic drawings of the best friends with dramatic, yet spare, dialogue in text bubbles make this a perfect early reader.

*Police Officers on Patrol* by Kersten Hamilton, R.W. Alley (Illustrator).
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0670063150



This book interestingly shows how police officers are always standing by to help maintain peace and safety in our everyday lives. Commonly reported instances (such as broken traffic lights, a missing child, and a bank robbery) that are appropriate for a young audience are included in the light-hearted story that illustrates what police officers do. Bright colors are used in the watercolor and color pencil illustrations to echo the hustle and bustle and cheerful atmosphere of the story.

*Pond Circle* by Betsy Franco, Stefano Vitale (Illustrator).
Margaret K. McElderry Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Science. Primary. 0. 1416940219




Beginning with "the jade green algae" bejeweling "the pond by Anna's house" and flitting swiftly to the "mayfly nymph that nibbled the algae," Franco's rhythmic text invites young readers to examine flora and fauna enmeshed in an ecological circle of consumption. A contemporary adaptation of **The House that Jack Built**, this picture book offers both a linguistic treat and an opportunity for primary grade children to learn environmental science concepts in a meaningful context. An artful glossary of terms deepens this experience. Although the text introduces the character Anna, it stops short of exploring the ways in which humans impact ecological systems. Teachers will certainly see this gap as an opportunity to extend the reading experience with lively conversations about how children and adults shape our local and global environmental circles.

*Poodle and Hound* by Kathryn Lasky, Mitch Vane (Illustrator).
Charlesbridge. 2009. 48 pages. $12.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1580893228



Poodle and Hound are the best of friends in an Odd Couple sort of way. Poodle loves the idea of planting flowers in the garden; Hound yearns for fresh vegetables. Hound looks at the night sky as an astronomer; Poodle uses what she sees there to create a fantastic story. While they may not always see things the same way at the start, they do find the middle ground in these three winning stories. Vane's witty illustrations enhance character development and the humorous episodes.

*Posy* by Linda Newbery, Catherine Rayner (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 1416971122



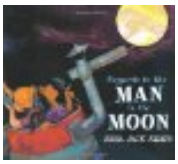

With simple slices of rhyming text suggesting a list poem, Newbery captures the everyday antics of a curious kitten. Her occasional use of alliteration adds linguistic depth. Children and adults will chuckle as Posy shows off as a "spider catcher," a "sofa scratcher," a "pillow sitter" and a "hissy spitter." Rayner's pen and ink illustrations in calming browns and tans—with splashes of cobalt blue—lend the text a balance of visual coherence and interest. An excellent entrée into playful language and aesthetic whimsy, **Posy** is a worthy addition to any home or classroom library.

*Raf* by Anke de Vries, Charlotte Dematons (Illustrator).
Lemniscaat. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1590787498




Raf, a toy giraffe with human wanderlust, decides to leave his child owner Ben for a while and go on an adventurous journey in Africa. The marvelous trip is marked by different places he visits and different kinds of animals he encounters; upon arriving at each new place, Raf sends a postcard to Ben. Raf's adventure ends as he returns home to Ben in a gift box on his birthday. The pastel and acrylic illustrations present Raf's journey in a colorful way, with postcards and backgrounds of different color themes that correspond to the settings of different places Raf visits.

*Regards to the Man in the Moon* by Ezra Jack Keats.
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0670011371




**Regards to the Man in the Moon** is a reprise of the 1981 book by Ezra Jack Keats. The paint and collage illustrations vibrantly support the tale about the power of imagination. The children used their imaginations to propel them "through worlds no one had ever seen before." They are brave, sometimes scared and always creative as they find adventure and keep friends. This book is a fine example of Keats' forte, with strong characters who make their ordinary lives extraordinary.

*Rita and Whatsit At the Beach* by Jean-Philippe Arrou-Vicnod, Oliver Tallec (Illustrator).
Chronicle Books. 2009. Unpaged. $14.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0811865517



Rita loves going to the beach, while her dog Whatsit doesn't love the beach that much. Rita enjoys getting physical at the beach, but Whatsit doesn't seem to be interested in anything more exciting than

sunbathing, munching on snacks, and killing time by chasing crabs. Suddenly there's a fantasy transition in the storyline that turns Whatsit into a Captain who's riding on a submarine and preparing to destroy Rita's sand castle. The two duel, and Rita is defeated. Captain Whatsit demands to have more sweets and treats, and the defeated Rita grants his wish. The ending foreshadows what may happen next – who knows, maybe Rita will take her revenge tomorrow! With simple pencil illustrations that have only red highlights on some parts, the visual images of this book resemble childish doodling that echoes well with the theme. The red and white striped endpapers may remind readers of their experiences at beach.

*Roawr!* by Barbara Joosse, Jan Jutte (Illustrator).
Philomel Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0399247777




The author states that she's especially fond of this book because it celebrates the "big hairy loudness" of boys. (It is definitely one that begs to be read aloud!) In addition to his loudness, the story applauds the main character's lively imagination. This is the first American picture book the illustrator has done, but he has illustrated over 100 titles in his native Netherlands and has won many of that country's highest awards.

*Robot Zot!* by Jon Scieszka, David Shannon (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416963944



Looming in space over the planet Earth is the menacing Robot Zot, a whaming, bamming attacker of...household aplliances! The actually tiny Zot and his sidekick, Best Pal Bot, escape with Earth's Queen - a toy phone - only to be challenged by "Earth's most fearsome Commander General" - a very friendly looking black dog. The happy ending (for everyone but the dog who of course gets blamed for all the destruction in the house) ensues with another hilarious adventure as Robot Zot and his friends approach another "planet" in their spaceship. Readers who look carefully at that page after seeing where the trio actually land on the next double-page spread will be well rewarded by one of many visual jokes in the book. This will be a favorite book for all those who love space, humor and robots who fall in love with purple-haired toy phones.

*Shades of People* by Shelley Rotner, Sheila M. Kelly.
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Informational Social Studies. Primary. Multicultural. 0823421910




This book for young children celebrates the many shades, not colors, of people. The photographs portray children of many shades who are celebrating themselves, each other and the diversity in their lives. This is an appealing book for young children, presented with straightforward, matter-of-fact text that encourages appreciation for the shades of difference, while acknowledging the similarities underneath. "In the world, there's light and dark, and everything in between."

*Skelly & Femur* by Jimmy Pickering.
Simon & Schuster. 2009. Unpaged. $12.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416971432




This is another story about Skelly, the skeleton girl, who is missing her buttons, whose dog Femur is missing its bone, and whose friends are all missing something in Skelly Manor. The storyline creates a suspenseful atmosphere; the turning point comes when the weird sound from the attic leads to a surprising and delicious ending. The Gothic-styled illustrations are dominated by black and purple, which give the book a slightly spooky tone. In addition, the other artistic elements such as the Rockwell typeface, the purple endpapers, and the many silhouettes in the illustrations also match well with the theme of this story.

*Skippyjon Jones, Lost in Spice* by Judy Schachner.
Dutton Juvenile. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0525479651




The adventurous kitty boy Skippyjon is back and heading to Mars this time, for Mars is red, and red is his favorite color! Skippyjon meets a Martian counterpart of himself - Martian-ito Skippito who also has large ears and a big head just as Skippyjon does. Finding a twin on Mars excites and cheers Skippyjon a lot, but the twins eventually fight over Skippyjon's sock monkey, forcing Skippyjon to hurl himself back to the Earth...just in time for dinner! In this not-so-typical, away-from-home adventure, young readers get to imagine travelling in outer space and meeting aliens. The pastel

illustrations depict the Martian setting with bizarre colors, while the changing sizes of the font provide dramatic effects. The Martians are strange enough to amaze young readers of the series.

*Sleep, Big Bear, Sleep* by Maureen Wright, Will Hillenbrand (Illustrator).
M. Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0761455604




Winter comes, and it's time for Big Bear to hibernate, yet he misunderstands Old Man Winter's instructions: "Sleep, Big Bear, Sleep!" and drives a jeep, sweeps a house, and climbs a steep mountain. Eventually understanding the right rhyming message, Big Bear goes back to his cave and does what he should do in the winter – sleep. The rhyming text is structured in a cumulative way suitable for being read aloud. The gray tone of the illustrations hints the season and also creates a sleepy atmosphere along with Big Bear's drowsy facial expressions. Big Bear's off-the-wall adventure before going to bed will appeal to children who also find so much to do before they go to sleep.

*Sneezy Louise* by Irene Breznak, Janet Pedersen (Illustrator).
Random House Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0375851690




Louise woke up one morning and found she couldn't stop sneezing; she had caught a bad cold! While she was at the breakfast table, in class, practicing ballet, and even listening to a bedtime story before going to bed, she couldn't help but sneeze and always forgot to cover her mouth. The purpose of the story is to teach children to cover their mouths and noses when sneezing. "Cover your mouth, please!" appears repetitively in the text. The outlined watercolor illustrations have a humorous look that echoes the funny story theme. The font alters between normal, italics, and large capitalized sizes to emphasize the dramatic effect of Louise's sneezes.

*Spells* by Emily Gravett.
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416982701




A small green frog finds a book of spells, uses some pages to create a pirate ship for sailing the Seven Seas, and then decides to try to piece together all the torn bits to create a "spell to become a Handsome Prince," as any fine fairy tale frog would want to do. Five split pages show the hilarious results (play with the endless number of spelling possibilities!) of his mistakes: "Hocus/Croakus/Carrotozabbit" results in "FABBIT," the top half of the page being frog and the bottom a puff-tailed rabbit. Gravett continues to play with other spell and spelling possibilities that will have young children laughing out loud, especially when frog hits upon "Bim Bam/Barebum/Alalamince." Hmmmm....what character rhymes with "mince" who may show up naked, hiding behind a few strategically placed torn bits of pages from the book? The fitting ending to the tale teaches comic a lesson. Always heed the warning: "SMALL PRINT/ Please read carefully."

*Stagecoach Sal: Inspired by a True Story* by Deborah Hopkinson, Carson Ellis (Illustrator).
Disney Hyperion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Primary. 0. 1423111494



From the time she was "knee high to a grasshopper," fearless Sal has enjoyed singing and driving the stage coach. Not even the infamous gentleman robber Poetic Pete has a chance when up against her resourceful wit and strong, resilient voice. The adventurous tale is told with Wild West similes, dialect and song lyrics (an Internet resource for the folk songs included is listed in the author's note). The softly colored pen and ink illustrations of all the action are washed in sepia, giving them an Old West feel. Hopkinson shares that her fictional characters are based on Delia Haskett Rawson, the first woman to carry the U.S. mail by stagecoach in California, and the outlaw then known as Black Bart.

*Ten Days and Nine Nights: An Adoption Story* by Yumi Heo.
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. Asian-American. 0375847189



In this endearing story about a Korean-American family's adoption of a baby girl from Korea, a young girl recounts her eager anticipation for the arrival of her new baby sister. As the family prepares to welcome the adopted baby, the protagonist counts down the remaining days before the baby's arrival.

The text is composed of quite simple and direct sentences that powerfully express the child's eagerness to meet her new sister. The illustrations resemble children's drawings, dovetailing with the story theme. The pencil and acrylic media, as well as the warm color palette, create an affectionate atmosphere, denoting the family's readiness to provide the adopted baby with loving care. The yellow endpapers with pink children's toys give readers a good hint at the story content.

*The Bog Baby* by Jeanne Willis, Gwen Millward (Illustrator).
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0375861769




A touching story that educates children what real love for wildlife is: letting them return to nature instead of keeping them as pets at home. Two sisters venture into a forest and find a Bog Baby, deciding to take him home and secretly keep as a pet. Everything is fine at the beginning, and the Bog Baby brings lots of fun to the sisters' everyday life, but soon the Bog Baby falls ill and becomes unhappy. Mom finally discovers the two sisters' secret and urges them to let Bog Baby return to his habitat because wild animals belong to the nature. The pencil and watercolor illustrations have a dreamy art style that highlights the uniqueness of the Bog Baby that implies that he's too extraordinary to be kept as a pet.

*The Busiest Street in Town* by Mara Rockliff, Sarah McMenemy (Illustrator).
Knopf Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0375840206




This is an interesting story about two good friends' efforts to make the fast pace on Rushmore Boulevard, the busiest street, slow down. Dissatisfied by the everyday hustle and bustle in front of her house, Agatha Walker decides to do something about it. She protests by bringing a batch of gingersnaps and a wingback chair and sits in the middle of the boulevard. Later her best friend Eulalie joins her, and magically, people passing by do slow down to have conversations with them and sample Agatha's delicious cookies. Afterwards, more changes occur: children stop by to play games after school; a neighbor plants honeysuckles to embellish the boulevard. Eventually, Rushmore Boulevard becomes Walker Road, its new name matching the new reality. The typeface in a variety of sizes enables readers to visualize and hear how noisy things are. Watercolor illustrations set the scene, while the illustrative photos of Agatha and Eulalie's lifelong friendship on the endpapers echo the story's theme.

*The Duchess of Whimsy* by Randall de Seve, Peter de Seve (Illustrator).
Philomel Books. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0399250956



The charm of this story lies in the contrasts between the two main characters, The Earl of Norm and The Duchess of Whimsy. One is quite ordinary and plain, whereas the other is quite extraordinary and charming. There are many interesting juxtapositions of the personalities and penchants of the two, building to the climax and perfect ending to the story. In the highly entertaining illustrations, readers can see the contrasting details of the two characters that reveal how different they are, from the duchess's roller skates and the two fairies that always follow her to the earl's ordinary apparel and his bulldog that looks as ordinary as he is. If readers look carefully on the last double-page spread, they'll see that the earl is wearing the same kind of roller skates as the duchess and the duchess's fairies are riding on the earl's dog who is wearing roller skates as well!

*The Hat That Wore Clara B.* by Melanie Turner-Denstaedt, Frank Morrison (Illustrator).
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. African-American. 0374327947




The story is about Mother's Sunday, an African American Baptist tradition, and the protagonist Clara B.'s close relationship with her grandma. Grandmother's hat links the different generations of the grandmother and the granddaughter, as well as serves as a symbol of passing on cultural traditions. The story is very fully developed and plotted out smoothly, and the language is quite formal and beautiful. The depiction of the intimacy between grandmother and granddaughter is very touching. The theme of the story faithfully reflects African American Baptist tradition. In addition, the pink color of the grandmother's apparel (her dress and her beautiful fancy hat) creates the warm, caring and approachable atmosphere of this picture book. Readers may even associate such gentle images with their own affable grandmothers!

*The Longest Night* by Marion Dane Bauer, Ted Lewin (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $17.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 082342054X



Open the book and a chill rises from the pages of this lyrical winter tale. Night is so very cold and so very silent and so very long. The sun is gone; all saw it "slink" or "plunge" below the horizon. In repetitive rhythm, each creature in its turn beckons the sun to return, but the wind knows the sun will only respond to the song of the tiny chickadee. The deep blues and grays of Lewin's watercolors are the cold and the dark of winter. His carefully rendered creatures struggle under the weight of winter's cold and darkness. They wait for the sun's promise of light and warmth. When "fingers of light/ peel back the blanket of darkness," soft hues of peach and yellow permeate the deep colors of the forest with the golden promise of spring. A wonderful book to read aloud to children during the depths of a northern winter or to children who don't experience that kind of winter where they live but will when they hear this book.

*The Mitten* by Jim Aylesworth, Barbara McClintock (Illustrator).
Scholastic Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Folk Literature. Primary. Europe (Eastern). 0439925444



Aylesworth retells this familiar Ukrainian tale using the repeated refrains of each animal wanting to get inside the mitten because its "toes are cold as ice," with those inside eventually relenting and saying, "Oh, okay! You can come in!" The illustrations of the ever-expanding mitten build tension until the resulting BURST - "What a shame!" - that sends startled animals flying off the page. Readers will enjoy comparing this retelling and its timeless American setting (the cozy kitchen is McClintock's) with Jan Brett's version of the story.

*The Scarecrow's Dance* by Jane Yolen, Bagram Ibatoulline (Illustrator).
Simon & Schuster. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1416937706



Through lyrical verse and dark illustrations infused with golden light at the climax of the story, scarecrow is given a brief taste of freedom as he leaps from his wooden pole and dances in the moonlight past the tractor, the barn "as red as blood," and the many sleeping farm animals in this theme-driven tale. It is a farm boy's prayer that reminds him of his place in the world, so he immediately returns to duty. "For anyone can dance,"/ Thought he,/"But only I/Can keep fields free."

*The Sleepy Little Alphabet: A Bedtime Story from Alphabet Town* by Judy Sierra, Melissa Sweet (Illustrator).
Knopf Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Concept. Primary. 0. 0375840028



Even though it's time for bed in Alphabet Town, trouble's afoot! "A is wide awake." Other personified child letters need to bathe; one jumps on the bed; one is naughty. Finally some are feeling "very, very snoozy" and "wobbly-woozy." Young children will be thoroughly entertained by the realistic bedtime situations, rich language, jaunty, rhyming text and cartoon-styled, anthropomorphic lower case letters (the adults are upper case) frolicking across the pages. There are items beginning with the featured letter to discover on each page as well. When "o and p upset the potty," googly-eyed octopus and penguin hop into the air. No wonder! A great companion to **Chicka Chicka Boom Boom**.

*The Song of Francis* by Tomie DePaola.
G.P. Putnam's Sons. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary. 0. 039925210X



St. Francis of Assisi is so filled with the love of God that he wants to share his joy with others. Even when Francis realizes that he is alone, he still sings, sharing his gift of song with the sun and the moon. The climax of the story is depicted only through the illustrations. In the two-page spread which is the pinnacle of the book, vibrant pinks, yellows, and oranges suggest a true celebration among Francis, the birds of the air, and a cadre of angels, who've flocked to his voice. The book is a visual delight of collage and bright colors and gives young readers an example of how to rejoice in one's blessings.

*The Three Little Tamales* by Eric Kimmel, Valeria Docampo (Illustrator).
Marshall Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Folk Literature. Primary. 0. 0761455191



Young readers were delighted by **The Runaway Tortilla**, so they requested a sequel. The author said it wasn't possible because that runaway tortilla had been eaten by a coyote at the end of the story, but he

satisfied them by creating another runaway tortilla who instigated the action in this story. The three tamales, however, soon take the spotlight. They will bring to mind the three little pigs and the perils they faced in dealing with the big bad wolf. The opportunities for comparing and contrasting the two stories, plus the humor and a few well chosen Spanish words, make this story a good candidate for reading aloud in the primary grades.

*The Tiptoe Guide to Tracking Fairies* by Ammi-Joan Paquette.
Tanglewood Press. 2009. Unpaged. $15.95. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 193371820X



Fanciful fairies grace the end pages of this wistful book, creating an invitation to indulge in fairy-finding excursions. Perfect for young fairy enthusiasts, the text guides readers through the natural world in search of evidence that fairies inhabit the area. Dandelion fluff is the perfect pillow material in a fairy hideout. Hollowed acorn shells are proof that fairies have been making sweet acorn mousse. Chipmunks are just the thing for bareback riding. Tulips, of course, make the ideal refuge for fairies when humans intrude on their territory. With charming mixed-media illustrations, the natural elements in the photographs pair well with the enchanting fairies, all of which have characteristics of the foliage in the photos. Readers will be drawn in by the title and will soon be tracking fairies in their own backyards and green spaces.

*This Little Bunny Can Bake* by Janet Stein.
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. 40 pages. $15.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 0375843132




Little Bunny and her other animal friends attend owl Chef George's dessert school. Though they are assiduous students and hard workers, it's still difficult for them to learn how to make desserts. Fortunately, practice makes perfect, and eventually all apprentices are able to make excellent final presentations of their dessert creations and graduate with confidence and pride from Chef George's school! Little Bunny, the best and the smartest among all students, is illustrated in pink to make him stand out from all other black-and-white characters. This book will be informative for young children learning a bit about dessert-making vocabulary found here and there in the illustrations as well as in the dessert recipes on the endpapers.

*Thunder Boomer!* by Shutta Crum, Carol Thompson (Illustrator).
Clarion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 0618618651




"A soft-touch tease" of a breeze is the beginning of the answer to mother's wish for the sweltering heat to break on the farm. Soon after, the swirling black sky brings the "zzzzt!" of lightning, the "rumble-brum-brum" of thunder, and the "ping! pang!" of hail, as the tension builds and everyone scurries for shelter. Light moments involving Dad's underwear will please young readers, as will the wonderful gift left behind when the storm moves on, leaving air which "smells as sweet as butter." The dramatic illustrations (done in watercolor, of course!), including the vignettes on the opening and closing endpapers, amplify the story and give life to the characters and the violent storm. The lyrical free verse, figurative language and onomatopoeia make this the perfect read aloud for primary grade students.

*Tony and the Pizza Champions* by Tony Gemignani, Matthhew Trueman (Illustrator).
Chronicle Books. 2009. 44 pages. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary. 0. 0811861627




Children will be fascinated by this true story of a team of five pizza-tossing masters winning the championship in a competition in Italy. Tony Gemignani, the captain of the pizza-tossing team, recounts his entire journey from recruiting team members in the States to attending the World Pizza Championship in Italy and beating rivals from all over the world. First-person perspective brings readers closer to the exciting action. Readers will be especially amazed by the astonishing pizza-tossing skills performed by each team member, as well as by their winning team-work. The comical pastel illustrations suit this interesting adventure well. The pizza recipes, as well as the step-by-step manual of pizza-tossing, in the appendix add even more fun to this book.

*Tortuga in Trouble* by Ann Whitford Paul, Ethan Long (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Primary. Hispanic. 0823421805




It's his three friends, not a woodcutter, who save Tortuga and his grandmother from the fearsome Coyote who wants to eat them along with everything in Tortuga's basket in this Southwestern desert version of **Little Red Riding Hood**. The cartoon characters' exaggerated eyes relay their chagrin, fear and, in the case of Coyote, his malevolence, along with their glee in digging into a delicious meal after the three friends ingeniously scare Coyote away. A glossary of Spanish words used in the story is included for those who don't speak the language.

*Two of a Kind* by Jacqui Robbins, Matt Phelan (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. 0. 141692437X



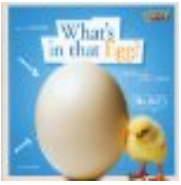

A touching story about the sincere and genuine friendship between two good friends, Anna and Julisa. Kayla and Melanie, also best friends in the girls' class, are also "two of a kind" but have quite different personalities from Anna and Julisa; they're aggressive, malicious, and narrow-minded. When Kayla and Melanie invite Anna to join them, she accepts, leaving Julisa alone. She later realizes how different they are from her and reconnects with Julisa, further assuring their true friendship. The pencil and watercolor illustrations portray the school setting of the story well while successfully highlighting the four protagonists.

*Watch Me Throw the Ball!* by Mo Willems.
Hyperion Books for Children. 2009. 56 pages. $8.99. Fantasy. Primary. 0. 1423113489




In the latest installment of the **Elephant and Piggie** series, Mo Willems addresses the concept of play through his comical characters. Piggie comes across Elephant as he's throwing a ball. Having never thrown a ball before, Piggie wants to give it a try. Elephant attempts to explain the complexities and seriousness of throwing a ball, but Piggie dives in to simply have fun. Fans will adore the quick, hilarious dialogue, coupled with Willems' signature simple, yet expressive drawings. Another fun addition to the reading shelf by this talented author/illustrator.

*What's in that Egg? A Book About Life Cycles* by Becky Baines.
National Geographic Society. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Informational Science. Primary. 0. 1426304080




From what they hold inside as they turn into the creatures they become to what happens after they hatch, every question young scientists may ask are included and answered in this introduction to eggs. Close-up photos show the juxtaposed true sizes of ostrich and hummingbird eggs along with many other creature's eggs, including turtles, frogs and fish. The light-hearted tone and simple information will further pique young readers' curiousity. Another in the fine series of Zigzag information books for kids.

*Who Would Like a Christmas Tree?: A Tree for All Seasons* by Ellen Obed, Ann Hunter (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Informational Science. Primary. 0. 0547046251



In a month-by-month presentation of the year, this beautiful picture book teaches young readers about the behaviors of a variety of wild creatures who inhabit pine trees that eventually become Christmas trees in December. The first-person narration brings young readers closer to the story. The watercolor and pencil drawings give a warm touch to the natural setting and creatures discussed, including the humans who come for the tree at the end of the year.

*Wink! The Ninja Who Wanted to be Noticed* by J.C. Phillipps.
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. Asia (Far East). 0670010928




Wink is an apprentice at the Summer Moon School for Young Ninjas and is excited to begin training. However, Wink has a very special characteristic that makes him unable to become a good ninja – he always wants to get attention from others, which is what ninjas mustn't do because they have to be stealthy and invisible! Though Wink is sent home by his Master Zutsu, he eventually finds his own way

to becoming a more visible ninja. This story illustrates the problem of not fitting in, and the ending encourages young readers because it assures them that it's totally fine to just be themselves. The lively cut paper, collage illustrations have an authentic Japanese feel by incorporating cultural elements that correspond well with the setting. This is a topic that many young readers will find irresistible.

*Winter's Tail: How One Little Dolphin Learned to Swim Again* by Craig Hatkoff, Juliana Hatkoff, Isabella Hatkoff.
Scholastic Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Science. Primary. 0. 0545123356




As a lifelong lover of dolphins, this book immediately grabbed my attention. Along the lines of their previous book about Owen the hippo and Mzee the tortoise, this is the true story of Winter, a bottlenose dolphin without a tail. As a baby dolphin, Winter got her nose and tail trapped in a crab trap and was freed by a fisherman. Injured and exhausted, Winter was taken to the Clearwater Marine Aquarium where she learned to swim without a tail. The owner of a prosthetics and orthotics company learned about Winter and created a prosthetic tail. This simple story, paired with arresting photographs of Winter's adventure, offers a rare look at an animal's triumph over disabilities that will educate and intrigue young children.

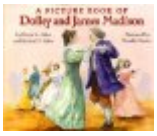
*You and Me and Home Sweet Home* by George Ella Lyon, Stephanie Anderson (Illustrator).
Random House Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary. African-American. 0689875894




After living for a long time with her mama in a small back room in her aunt and uncle's house, a young girl's "church family" builds them a new house of their own. The love and care and hard work that go into creating a home are described in the young girl's voice and shown in evocative watercolor illustrations that depict not only the building process but the feelings of the girl and the builders well. The author's note shares that the book grew out of a Women's Build project that she had worked on in Lexington, Kentucky.

# Primary/Intermediate

*A Picture Book of Dolley and James Madison* by David A. Adler, Michael S. Adler, Ronald Himler (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $17.95. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0823420094



This biography of America's fourth president and his wife, James and Dolley Madison, gives readers a reliable overview of their impact on America's early 19th century political history. The authors place more emphasis on James Madison than on his wife by highlighting his contributions to the writing of the Constitution and the creation of the three branches of government and his friendships with other politicians of his time, such as James Monroe. Anecdotes about personable first lady Dolley Madison include her famous deed of saving President George Washington's portrait when the Executive Mansion was burned by the British during the War of 1812. The pencil and watercolor illustrations are true to the 19th century setting and also give the story a genuine historical look.

*Alvin Ho: Allergic to Camping, Hiking, and Other Natural Disasters* by Lenore Look, LeUyen Pham (Illustrator).
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. 170 pages. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. Chinese-American. 0375857052




Phobic second grader Alvin Ho is back, and this time is mortified beyond belief because his father has decided that just like his hero, Henry David Thoreau, Alvin should learn to love nature by going on an overnight camping trip. Lenore Look knows just how children think and talk and the kinds of situations they find most scary, and she presents them with a great deal of humor and understanding. Big brother Calvin, who always seems to have the right answer to everything, uses Dad's credit card (this is definitely an emergency situation) to mollify Alvin by purchasing all kinds of expensive camping equipment from a website. His uncle, who he's sure is some sort of secret agent, gives Alvin all kinds of camping tips. Some, like using dryer lint to start a fire, are quite helpful, others result in dire, though ultimately quite funny, consequences. Children who relish this first-person account of Alvin's latest misadventures will also enjoy Look's books about Ruby Lu.

*Bobby Bramble Loses His Brain* by Dave Keane, David Clark (Illustrator).
Clarion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Fantasy. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0547056443



As soon as readers see Bobby's wayward brain on the opening pages with the Library of Congress information, they know this is going to be a hilarious story. They won't be disappointed. When Bobby doesn't heed his mother's warning, his head does crack open just like Humpty Dumpty's. And his escaping brain certainly does have "a mind of its own." The cumulative story has one person after another trying to capture Bobby's brain with comic results. Filled with wordplay and very funny illustrations of his brain wobbling along on spinal cord, legs and feet, the book will be a favorite of anyone who loves a good laugh.

*Calvin Coconut: Trouble Magnet* by Graham Salisbury, Jacqueline Rogers (Illustrator).
Wendy Lamb Books. 2009. 152 pages. $12.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. Multicultural. 0385737017




In this first book of a new series set in Hawaii, well meaning Calvin heads pellmell from one misadventure to the next as summer ends and 4th. grade begins. Male readers will especially identify with the kind of trouble Calvin repeatedly gets himself into in episode after episode. While readers will find plenty of humor in these predicaments, Salisbury also considers serious topics like how Calvin feels about the fact that his father, a singer who legally changed all their last names from Novio to the dreadful Coconut, abandoned the family four years ago. Rogers's many black and white illustrations help flesh out the characters and situations.

*City I Love* by Lee Bennett Hopkins, Marcellus Hall (Illustrator).
Abrams Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0810983273




This specialized anthology celebrates urban life with 18 lyrical poems about cities around the world. City lover Hopkins wrote the poetry in a variety of styles over 39 years. He knows just what sounds and subjects will appeal to children whether they're familiar with big city life or not. Marcellus Hall's cartoon style illustrations provide details about the unnamed cities that will have children guessing what city is the subject of each poem. The endpapers show a world map that highlights the 18 cities included in the book and helps young readers with their city guesses.

*Come to the Castle: A Visit to a Castle in Thirteenth-Century England* by Linda Ashman, S. D. Schindler (Illustrator).
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. 40 pages. $17.95. Historical Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. Great Britain. 1596431555



Humorously written and illustrated, this picture book presents medieval history with a cast of characters living in England during the Middle Ages. The story begins with the Earl of Daftwood's (readers will soon find how suitably named he is!) perfect but boring everyday life. He decides to host a banquet for amusement, clearly not understanding what kinds of toil his servants will go through to prepare it. Interestingly, the story is told from the perspectives of different characters, including the herald, the cook, the cleansing servant, the knight, and even the Earl's daughter. The rhymed text sparkles with wit and humor. The Gothic font and illustrations – from the decorated picture frames and the outfits of characters, to the textured parchment look and colored background of each double-page spread - give this book a genuine Middle Ages look. While readers will be highly entertained, they'll also learn what castle life was like long ago.

*Crow Call* by Lois Lowry, Bagram Ibatoulline (Illustrator).
Scholastic Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0545030358



Lowry retells a story from her childhood when she reconnects with her father, who has become a stranger after being away for so long during WWII. In the still, early morning hours, they are off to hunt the crows who are eating all the crops, talking about fear. "Hunter" is a word that scares her; killing isn't something she wants to help her father do. The gentle ending is perfect for the story and goes a long way in helping this little girl, in her oversized, wool plaid shirt, and her loving father regain what had been lost. Ibatoulline uses soft grays and browns to create the late fall setting and the wistful face of the child seen through the car windshield next to her sad-eyed father. The last double-page spread shows the two happily leaving the woods, holding hands, walking toward the hope-filled future.

*Dinothesaurus: Prehistoric Poems and Paintings* by Douglas Florian.
Beach Lane Books. 2009. 56 pages. $17.99. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 1416979786




**Dinothesaurus** is a collection of playful dinosaur poems and mixed media, collage illustrations that enhance the book's witty and fanciful tone. Filled with clever word play and plenty of actual dinosaur facts, the book will be a classroom favorite. It includes pronunciation guides, a 'glossarysaurus', and bibliography, plus a list of museums and recommended web sites. Readers will be delighted by the humorous treatment of this popular topic and may be inspired to write their own dino poems.

*Excellent Emma* by Sally Warner, Jamie Harper (Illustrator).
Viking. 2009. 130 pages. $14.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. Multicultural. 067006310X




In this latest addition to the popular series, students in Emma's third-grade class are at their competitive worst as they prepare for and try to win awards at Winter Games Day. Warner knows just how students this age think, talk and act, so readers will see themselves and others in Emma's situations and in her quest to outdo her distant rival Lettice Wallingford and impress her absent father by winning at something too. The issues that arise with winning and losing are explored in a light-hearted, realistic manner that could naturally lead to some illuminating discussions.

*Falling Down the Page: A Book of List Poems* Georgia Heard (Editor).
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. 45 pages. $16.95. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 1596432209



People make lists; "poets meticulously craft their words to make list poems." And so Georgia Heard begins her entertaining and informative book with the hope that young readers will be inspired by the list poems in her collection and will want to write their own. Turn the book on its side and begin reading long lists of poetic items by poets such as Jane Yolen, who attests when cleaning out her desk that "each piece of junk's/my history." She'll have students pulling everything out of their own desks to discover just who they are as well. Heard contributes "Oak Tree," a clever concrete list poem that will have students turning the book yet again. Dotlich's school poems are sure to hit home and spark young poets' imaginations. And the final poem, a to-do list by Liz Rosenberg, will have students thinking in a new way about their own daily rituals.

*For the Duration: The War Years* by Tomie dePaola.
G.P. Putnam's Sons. 2009. 99 pages. $15.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399252096




The latest addition to the 26 Fairmont Avenue series is set in 1942 when Tomie is in second grade. Happier moments of his young life, like getting one of the lead roles in his dance recital, are juxtaposed with the death of his favorite cousin, Blackie, whose plane is shot down by the Germans, and his older brother's cruelty because he asserts that Tomie is a "sissy." Life changes "for the duration," not only because of rationing and men going off to war, but also because of what is happening at home. Tomie's childhood worries, his artistic abilities, sensitivity, friendships, and wonderful relationship with his grandfather, will resonate with readers now, whether or not they face similar challenges.

*Fu Finds the Way* by John Rocco.
Hyperion Books for Children. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. Asia (Far East). 1423109651



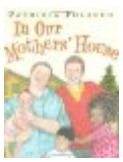

This interesting picture book conveys the central notion of Taoism ( a philosophy that has a long history in China) or “the way,” meaning any skills developed through great practice. While helping with farm chores one day, Young Fu, a farmer's son, accidentally hurls a handful of mud that hits the powerful General Chang's face. Greatly enraged, General Chang challenges Fu to a duel the next morning. Perplexed and extremely frightened, Fu turns to his master for help. To his surprise, the master doesn’t teach him about fencing but about the art of making tea! How Fu appeases the general with only a teapot shows the essence of Taoism. The illustrations are done in a delicate, Chinese artistic style. The metaphoric images of caterpillar, chrysalis, and butterfly that accompany the tea making training highlight Fu’s progress.

*Imogene's Last Stand* by Candace Fleming, Nancy Carpenter (Illustrator).
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0375836071




Passionate and resourceful history prodigy (her first words were "Four score and seven years ago") Imogene Tripp has to save the Liddleville Historical Society museum twice, the first time from neglect and the second time from the wrecking ball. Quoting famous Americans right and left, she valiantly tries to rally the town behind her cause. The over-the-top and fortuitous solution to Imogene's quest is as perfect as Professor Pastmatters' name. Pen-and-ink illustrations add to Imogene's forthright yet comedic antics and enhance the underlying message. End papers include "Imogene Tripp's Historical Tidbits."

*In Our Mother's House* by Patricia Polacco.
Philomel Books. 2009. 48 pages. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. GLBT. 039925076X



A daughter poignantly recalls her childhood in a nontraditional family. Marmee and Meema, her two mothers, raise their three adopted children with warmth and an all-encompassing love. She includes memories of joyful holidays, outings, family gatherings, and daily life in this well-adjusted household. The family is accepted by most of the community and, when a neighbor makes disparaging remarks, Marmee and Meema explain that the woman is afraid because she just doesn’t understand them. This is a wonderful story that provides a positive view of growing up with lesbian parents.

*In the Belly of an Ox: The Unexpected Photographic Adventures of Richard and Cherry Kearton* by Rebecca Bond.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. Great Britain. 0547076754




A story of two late-19th century naturalists and nature photographers, Richard and Cherry Kearton, this book reproduces the Kearton brothers' photographic adventures through idyllic watercolor paintings and lyrical text. Born in Yorkshire, both worked for a publisher in London. The brothers had great zeal for photographing nature, especially different species of birds and their nests. To take pictures of these easily scared wild creatures, the brothers invented various devices for deception - hence the title - and carried them everywhere to take their vivid photos of birds. The brothers eventually published the first nature book completely illustrated by photographs. The watercolor illustrations show the settings where their photos were taken and some of their adventures. Black-and-white photos of bird nests in the back give readers a glimpse of the Kearton brothers' pursuit of nature.

*Look to the Stars* by Buzz Aldrin, Wendell Minor (Illustrator).
G.P. Putnam's Sons. 2009. 40 pages. $17.99. Informational Science. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399247211



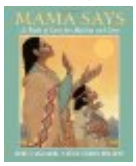

Astronaut Buzz Aldrin gives a personalized, sweeping history of the space program, from the early observations of Capernicus and Newton, to the experiments of Robert Goddard to his own walk on the moon and beyond, tantalizing young readers with the possibility of their own voyage in the future. Minor's detailed, realistic paintings of each vignette of space exploration extend the information of the text. Numerous quotes from those featured, resources, websites and an extensive, double-page spread timeline are also included. Aldrin has successfully dedicated himself to educating young people about space, to "look to the stars and dare to dream!" just as he did.

*Make Way for Dyamonde Daniel* by Nikki Grimes, R. Gregory Christie (Illustrator).
Putnam. 2009. 74 pages. $10.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. African-American. 0399251758



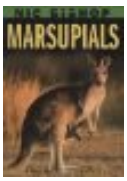

"Dyamonde Daniel was a gem just waiting to be discovered. Just ask her." Although she's new to school, third grader Dyamonde is outgoing, smart and self-assured. All she needs is a best friend. On the other hand, Free, the new boy who joins the class who Dyamonde secretly nicknames Rude Boy, has a completely different way of dealing with the unknown. How the two finally become best friends is very believable. Readers ready for chapter books, especially those who have had to deal with moving, will identify with these characters and their situations. The simple question and answer at the end of the book show that this is the first in a series that will be a particularly welcome addition to 2nd and 3rd grade classroom libraries.

*Mama Says: A Book of Love for Mothers and Sons* by Rob Walker, Leo and Diane Dillon (Illustrator).
Blue Sky Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. Multicultural. 0439932084




Although the subtitle of this inviting picturebook indicates that it is for mothers and sons, it speaks to parents and children everywhere. The lyrical presentation of universal values across twelve different cultures begs to be read--or sung--aloud. Full-color illustrations with the characteristic sculptural quality of the Dillons' art are full of details that readers will enjoy pouring over. The text is rendered in both English and eleven different languages ranging from Cherokee to Amharic, Russian to Arabic.

*Marsupials* by Nic Bishop.
Scholastic. 2009. 48 pages. $17.99. Informational Science. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 043987758X



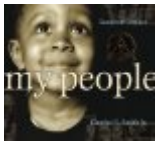

What is a marsupial? Through stunning, close-up photos of the animals, some rarely seen, and engaging, informative text with enticing questions to immediately interest readers, Bishop surveys all types of marsupials from the well-known kangaroos and koalas to wombats, Tasmanian devils and the tiny dibblers and dunnarts. Key information is highlighted in bright colors and larger font size, while dotted lines hop from page to page. "It is easy to marvel at marsupials" when reading this fascinating, well designed book. It's also easy to see that Bishop spent 6 often trying months in Australia researching and photographing the marsupials in this book.

*Moxy Maxwell Does Not Love Practicing the Piano (But She Does Love Being in Recitals)* by Peggy Gifford, Valorie Fisher (Illustrator).
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. 177 pages. $12.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0375844880



Moxy's dramatic preparation for her piano recital duet with her sister includes creating an amazing outfit to wear, dreaming of a large and appreciative audience, practicing her bow...everything but actually practicing "Heart and Soul." In this hilarious third book in the series, with its short chapters with witty titles, Moxy finally isn't certain she can go on. Yes, Moxy may have lost her moxy! Photos taken by her brother Mark of Moxy, her family and even the stage door are interspersed throughout the book, adding to the fun and obligatory drama.

*My People* by Langston Hughes, Charles R. Smith Jr. (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. African-American. 1416935401




Poet Smith's dramatically lit, action-packed sepia photos of African-Americans of all ages capture the celebratory mood of Hughes' poem describing the beauty of his people. This is a perfect marriage of images and words, so moving to behold. Read it aloud, boldly in Ashley Bryan fashion, and see how powerful the combination is.

*Nasreen's Secret School* by Jeanette Winter.
Beach Lane Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. Asia (Northern). 1416994378



Young readers will gain insights into what's happening in Afghanistan as they are introduced to Nasreen and her grandmother who will do whatever it takes to ensure her education after her father and mother were taken from her. As gray clouds and sad faces give way to light blue skies and the peace of reading, knowledge "will always be with her, like a good friend." Winter includes an author's note that gives details about the Global Fund for Children and background information about life under the Taliban that enhances the bravery of these women in establishing schools for girls.

*Never Smile at a Monkey: And 17 Other Important Things to Remember* by Steve Jenkins.
Hyperion Books for Children. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Informational Science. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 061896620X




Readers will be intrigued by the title and will only have to turn to the back cover to discover what they would see - an angry rhesus monkey baring dangerous teeth - if they unwittingly do decide to smile! Jenkins includes alliterative warnings ("Never harass a hippopotamus...or jostle a jellyfish...or touch a tang") and short introductions to many other seemingly harmless but very dangerous creatures. His eye-catching, realistic cut-paper illustrations make the book one that will be a favorite for reading aloud and poring over repeatedly.

*Once Upon a Twice* by Denise Doyen, Barry Moser (Illustrator).
Random House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Fantasy. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0375856129




Jam was a mouse with dreams and bravado who, against the advice of the elder mice, broke the rules and went on a moonlight adventure. Denise Doyen, in her first children's book, cleverly uses rhyme and created words to tell Jam's story. The effect is similar to Lewis Carroll's "Jaberwocky." "Jamagination in a flurry:/I won't scamper! I won't scurry!/A clever mousling need not worry./Furry overconfidence." The lovely, moon-lit illustrations by award-winning illustrator Barry Moser keep the reader enchanted as the story unfolds. Jam learns the lesson of a lifetime as the reader or listener enjoys the story, the skillful use of verse, and the atsmospheric visuals.

*Orangutan Tongs: Poems to Tangle Your Tongue* by Jon Agee.
Disney Hyperion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 1423103157




These witty, often laugh-out-loud funny, tongue twisting poems beg to be read aloud. Just try reading poems such as "Walter and the Waiter" or "Patty Petty" quickly and see how successful you are! Agee is the consummate wordsmith who always entertains with his poems and his perfectly in tune, cartoon-styled illustrations featuring the characters involved in each ridiculous situation. His genuine love of words and silliness is so apparent that even the most reluctant poetry antagonist won't be able to resist this latest addition to his impressive wordplay canon.

*Our Abe Lincoln* by Jim Aylesworth, Barbara McClintock (Illustrator).
Scholastic Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0439925487




This book is dedicated to the children at the Lincoln Elementary School, and on the first spread there is a scene in an auditorium where children are preparing for the play “Our Abe Lincoln.” The rhymed text accurately tells President Lincoln’s story, featuring different stages of his life from early childhood to adult years when he becomes smart Abe Lincoln, strong Abe Lincoln, and great Abe Lincoln. A detailed author’s note that expands upon the verses performed by the students is included at the end of the book. The illustrations are always framed by the draping stage curtains of the children's play. In addition, the cross-hatched and watercolor drawings enhance the warm feeling of this story of eager child actors, their audience and the man they admire. The endpapers are printed with the lyrics for “Our Abe Lincoln" (sung to the tune of "The Old Gray Goose") which is adapted by the author from the popular song sung during Lincoln’s campaigns for the Presidency. This is a fine introduction to Lincoln for younger readers who will enjoy singing along.

*Paula Bunyan* by Phyllis Root, Kevin O'Malley (Illustrator).
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0374357595



You probably didn't know that tall tale hero Paul Bunyan had a little sister who was "as tall as a pine tree and as strong as a dozen moose," who lived in the North Woods where mosquitoes were so huge they could carry away her pet bear. She could perform just as many amazing feats as he, though she was much more inclined to plant trees than cut them down. This outsized tale is an homage to ecology and the powerful beauty of the forests and the creatures who live in them. O'Malley's rustic illustrations perfectly capture the setting and gigantic characters.

*Peaceful Heroes* by Jonah Winter, Sean Addy (Illustrator).
Arthur A. Levine Books. 2009. 60 pages. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. Multicultural. 0439623073




**Peaceful Heroes** is a source of comfort amid the day-to-day strain of violence, war, and turmoil. Jonah Winter gives profiles of 14 people whose lives reflect “a kind of heroism of which we are all capable.” Some heroes spoke in loud voices, others in hushed tones; some were killed for their efforts, others who endured used their lives to help others and to make important changes in laws and in mindsets. Jesus of Nazareth is one such hero. He used love to transform his enemies. William Feehan, a top fireman in New York City, sacrificed his life to save others on September 11, 2001. His heroism, just like that of the others profiled in this book, is a story of strength—and a challenge to us all. Addy’s textured paintings highlight the icons in muted colors while symbols of peace adorn the book.

*Red Sings from Treetops: A Year in Colors* by Joyce Sidman, Pamela Zagarenski (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0547014945




Colors and seasons come to life in this well designed book filled with witty verbal and visual images. In spring bold red does sing ”cheer-cheer-cheer;” green is much more "shy;" “yellow shouts with light.” And so the seasons drift by, page by page, filled with every sound and sight, smell and taste, texture and touch imaginable, beginning and ending with the color red in verse and illustrations and on the endpapers. Children will thrill to suggestions such as “Fall smells/Purple” or “winter tastes White.” They’ll be intrigued by thinking of color and season changes in new ways. Elongated, elaborately

dressed characters personify the colors, fancifully exploring each season and relishing the sensations that greet them throughout the year.

*Redwoods* by Jason Chin.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Informational Science. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 1596434309




While sitting on a bench waiting for the subway, a young boy discovers a book - the very book children are also reading - featuring him on its cover. A fantastic adventure begins the minute he opens the book; dinosaurs peer in the window of the subway car as the boy reads about the coastal redwoods existing when they did. The boy soon magically finds himself in the redwood forests of Northern California, where he (and the book's readers) learns a great deal about the giant trees, their history and biology, and why their preservation is so important. Lush illustrations deftly intertwine fantasy and reality and add extra information to the text. The perfect ending, reminiscent of **Jumanji** and similar fantasies, leads to another character's redwood adventure. The urge to join her will be great!

*Ron's Big Mission* by Rose Blue, Corinne J. Naden, Don Tate (Illustrator).
Dutton Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. African-American. 0525478493




Those familiar with the space program will recognize the name Ron McNair, one of the astronauts who lost their lives on the space shuttle Challenger in 1986. The story told in this book shows that he was an avid reader and child hero with another important mission when he was nine; Ron wanted his own public library card at a time when African Americans living in his South Carolina hometown were not allowed to check out books. Young children today may be shocked that the librarian called the police and will be amazed at the boy's courage. Tate's stylized yet realistic illustrations make the incident, based on a true story, and people, both real and fictionalized, come to life for today's readers.

*Runaway Mummy: A Petrifying Parady* by Michael Rex.
Putnam. 2009. Unpaged. $15.99. Fantasy. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399252037




Just as the mother assures her child in Margaret Wise Brown's **Runaway Bunny** that she'll always lovingly follow him no matter where he goes, Mother Mummy affectionately assures her little runaway mummy, "I'll get you! For you are my rotten little mummy!" The little mummy leads his mother on a wild and ghoulish (though far more humorous than petrifying) chase shown in illustrations that parody Clement Hurd's style and color palette, including his green room from **Goodnight Moon**. Children will enjoy comparing the two books to truly understand what a parody is.

*Sonia Sotomayor: A Judge Grows in the Bronx* by Jonah Winter, Edel Rodriguez (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. Latino-American. 1442403039



Using the repeated metaphor of "the most beautiful moonflower that blossoms in an unexpected place" in both text and softly glowing illustrations and endpapers, the newest Supreme Court justice, and the first Latina to hold the office, is introduced to young readers. Young Sonia "blossoms" because of the love of her family, particularly her hard-working mother. She works just as hard to achieve eventual greatness in the face of adversity. Fittingly, the text is presented in both English and Spanish. Winter's Author's Note fills in additional details about Sotomayor's background.

*Stars Above Us* by Geoffrey Norman, E.B. Lewis (Illustrator).
G.P. Putnam's Sons. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399247246



Amanda finds the dark scary, until her father shows her that nighttime is full of cheerful sounds (crickets) and dancing lights (stars and fireflies). The two bond as Amanda's father helps her paste paper stars to her bedroom ceiling, teaches her about the constellations, and names a star for them to share. When Amanda's father leaves the family to serve in the armed forces, Amanda uses her father's teachings about the stars to face a different kind of darkness—separation from a parent. Author Geoffrey Norman and renowned illustrator E.B. Lewis handle this topic with a gentle expressiveness that subtly invites children to respond

and connect to the protagonist. During a time when many children are separated from parents serving in the military, this is an important book to offer the young readers in our homes, classrooms, and libraries.

*Steady Hands: Poems About Work* by Tracie Vaughn Zimmer, Megan Halsey (Illustrator), Sean Addy (Illustrator).
Clarion Books. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0618903518



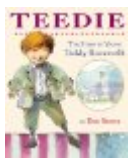

**Steady Hands** is a new book about careers, but not the ordinary look at what the future might hold. Some careers, such as the baker, the librarian and the teacher, are expected in a book for children. Others are careers students might be considering, such as a surgeon, an electrician, or a flight attendant. Some are jobs that may be new ideas for the reader, including dog walker, entrepreneur or park ranger. All entries are free verse poetry, and all provide unique thoughts about the work. The janitor "senses all the secret wishes a building whispers in the night." The retail clerk "is glad she doesn't have to see what becomes of the clothes she sells." The ballet instructor "leads them in their first steps toward grace." So what is the steady hand? It could hold a pencil, a scalpel, a spoon, a paintbrush, a guitar. Halsey and Addy's textured mixed media illustrations lend the text a sense of three-dimensionality that invites readers to engage viscerally with the poems. The book is refreshing, thought-provoking, conversation-starting, and inspirational for readers of all ages.

*Tarra & Bella: The Elephant and Dog Who Became Best Friends* by Carol Buckley.
Putnam. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Science. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399254439




In this sweet story of true friendship, Buckley tells of Tarra, the first resident of an elephant sanctuary in Tennessee who was the only elephant that was not paired with an elephant partner. She was befriended by Bella, a stray dog, who became her constant companion. When Bella was seriously injured and was taken to the barn for treatment, Tarra waited outside of the barn until Bella recovered and could be returned to their home. Young readers will enjoy the fact that this endearing story, accompanied by photos of the two, is true.

*Teedie: The Story of Young Teddy Roosevelt* by Don Brown.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. Unpaged. $16.00. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0618179992



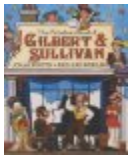

This biography of Theodore "Teddy" Roosevelt (1858-1919), the 26th President of the United States, gives a complete overview of his life. As a child, Roosevelt was weak physically but strong mentally and had a hunger for knowledge. Later in his adolescence, he was intentionally involved in all sorts of sports to train himself to be a stronger person. Roosevelt's achievements as president, such as establishing national parks and preserves, building the Panama Canal, and ending the Russian-Japanese War, are highlighted. The uplifting theme illustrating how a delicate, nervous, timid little boy later transformed into a political giant of American politics would be especially encouraging for children, teaching them to have faith in themselves and to constantly improve in order to achieve.

*Testing the Ice* by Sharon Robinson, Kadir Nelson (Illustrator).
Blue Sky Press. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. African-American. 0545052513



Every icon has an ordinary existence hidden behind their extraordinary persona. Jackie Robinson is no exception. This book presents the baseball legend as a family man. His daughter Sharon narrates, recalling his mastery at storytelling. She also recalls her father's fear of drowning in the ice-skating pond behind their home. One winter, Jackie demonstrated the same courage that allowed him to break the color line in Major League Baseball while testing the ice of the skating pond, making sure it was safe for Sharon, her brothers, and her friends to play on. Kadir Nelson's realistic paintings appear to have been snatched from the Robinson family photo album because they're so life-like.

*The Fabulous Feud of Gilbert and Sullivan* by Jonah Winter, Richard Egielski (Illustrator).
Arthur A. Levine Books. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Informational Arts. Primary/Intermediate. Great Britain. 0439930502




While Mr. Gilbert and Mr. Sullivan created many operas together in Victorian England, their very different personalities led to a feud that could have ended their collaboration. Mr. Gilbert often created silly plots,

themes and repetitive stories, whereas Mr. Sullivan had always wanted to write grand operas. Luckily, when it looked as though the two would never be able to work together again, Mr. Gilbert was finally inspired by a Japanese play and the two created their most famous opera, The Mikado. The illustrations contrast the happily imaginative world of Gilbert and Sullivan's operas with the grim London streets of that period when children worked in factories and poverty was common. The book provides just enough historical background and theatrical information for young readers who may have never heard of the famous pair.

*The Fantastic Undersea Life of Jacques Cousteau* by Dan Yaccarino.
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. Europe (Western). 0375855734



No one who knows anything about the famous undersea explorer will be surprised by the first sentence in the book: "Jacques Cousteau loved the sea." His love led to a number of discoveries, including the invention of the aqua lung, or scuba tank, that allowed him - and everyone else wanting to explore the world under the sea - to become a part of the world he loved. Whimsical sea creatures and a lanky, masked Cousteau with his ubiquitous tank and fins, drawn in Yaccarino's cartoon style, float amidst bubbles in a yellow, green, flaming red or deep blue sea. Cousteau quotes about how it felt to swim without having to repeatedly surface or his hope for the future of humankind give great insight into the philosopher scientist and are a fine addition to the interesting information that the author shares about the famous explorer, who would have turned 100 in 2010. A list of further resources is included at the end of the book for young readers who want to learn more about Cousteau, his fellow explorers and their ship, the Calypso.

*The Lion & the Mouse* by Jerry Pinkney.
Little, Brown. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Folk Literature. Primary/Intermediate. Europe (Mediterranean). 0316013560



On the front of the jacket, there is no title or author listed; there is just an enormous, tawny lion who looks aside, as if viewing the soft, brown mouse profiled on the back of the jacket, who is seemingly looking back at him. This is a wordless tour de force of Aesop's well known fable. Except for the occasional animal sound or the "putt-putt-putt" of the jeep with its fateful trap, no words are needed to tell the dynamic story of the brave mouse and the lion who goes against his nature when he releases her. Together they show that dire adversity can be overcome with help whether the one in need is mighty or meek. Pinkney explains that he has set the tale in the Serengeti plains of Tanzania and Kenya, and he populates his story with the animals found there. He often pans in for close-ups of the action. Children who carefully pore over his dynamic illustrations will recognize just what the little mouse is climbing on in her escape from the owl long before the mouse realizes her near fatal mistake.

*The Outlandish Adventures of Liberty Aimes* by Kelly Easton, Greg Swearingen (Illustrator).
Wendy Lamb Books. 2009. 214 pages. $15.99. Fantasy. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 037583771X



This is a story that brings to mind memories of Matilda and Pippi Longstocking, while quickly pulling the reader into the intriguing and depressing world of Liberty Aimes. Libby is a prisoner in her home, where she waits on her terrible parents, until one day she uncovers a wealth of children's books hidden beneath some floorboards. With the likes of Alice in Wonderland dancing in her mind, Liberty finds the courage to venture into her father's forbidden laboratory and makes an incredible discovery that forever changes her life. Kelly Easton has created a page-turning adventure with quirky characters and outrageous turns that will engage and amuse any reader.

*The Plot Chickens* by Mary Jane Auch, Herb Auch (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Fantasy. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0823420876



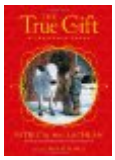
So, you want to be an "eggcellent" writer but aren't sure where to begin? Follow Henrietta's hilarious writing journey as she develops her story with the help of her aunts and eight rules every author should know. The story is filled with egg and hen wordplay: "You need to hatch a plot." When Henrietta receives a nasty rejection letter from Hunter Fox, she vows "not to brood over her rejection." The cartoon-styled illustrations are as witty as the writing. All children will be engaged by this funny story (as they are by the other clever books by this pair), but those who are writing will also love Henrietta's tips for success.

*The Story of Snow: The Science of Winter's Wonder* by Mark Cassino, Jon Nelson, Ph.D..
Chronicle Books. 2009. 34 pages. $16.99. Informational Science. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0811868664




Beginning with deep blue snow crystals on light blue end papers, children are introduced to the fascinating "story of snow." How are the crystals formed? Why are none the same? Why do snow crystals have different shapes - stars, plates and columns? The answers to these questions and many others are provided in easily understood, scientifically accurate explanations. Cassino's amazing, magnified photos of the crystals allow children to see that snow crystals aren't perfect, that they may have bumps, or can be formed one on top of the other. The book ends with tips for young scientists about how to catch and observe their own snow crystals.

*The True Gift: A Christmas Story* by Patricia MacLachlan, Brian Floca (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. 81 pages. $12.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 141699081X




Lily and Liam were always excited to spend Christmas at their grandparents' farm, but this year one of the first things they noticed was that "White Cow stood alone in the big meadow." Not only was she alone, but "her eyes were sad." How the children decide to remedy the lonely cow's predicament makes a heartfelt, old fashioned Christmas story that would be perfect to share with children in the weeks before the holiday. Floca's realistic, black and white illustrations add to the story's warmth and charm.

*The Underwear Salesman* by J. Patrick Lewis, Serge Bloch (Illustrator).
Ginee Seo Books. 2009. 64 pages. $16.99. Poetry. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0689853254




This is a highly entertaining book of humorous poetry describing various jobs, some common and some more unusual, such as a crossword puzzle maker or a sword swallower. The rhyming poems are rife with puns and other wordplay. They are accompanied by complementary collage illustrations that extend the wit.

*The Yellow Tutu* by Kirsten Bramsen, Carin Bramsen (Illustrator).
Random House Books for Young Readers. 2009. 40 pages. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0375851682



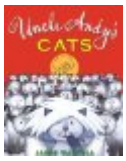
Margo receives a yellow tutu as her birthday gift and decides to wear it on her head to school, for she thinks that makes her look like a shining sun. Excited at first about this new idea but later frustrated by her classmates' taunts, Margo eventually finds support from Pearl, who's learning ballet and has a pink tutu. The touching friendship between them is built as the considerate Pearl invites Margo to play tea party with her while wearing their tutus on their heads. This story has a clear theme of mutual understanding and friendship; it is also semi-autobiographical because it's based on the author's childhood experience. Soft lines and shapes of the digital illustrations make the book more appealing. Endpapers are filled with yellow tutu patterns that correspond with the theme.

*Tricking the Tallyman* by Jacqueline Davies, S.D. Schindler (Illustrator).
Knopf Books for Young Readers. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Historical Fiction. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0375839097



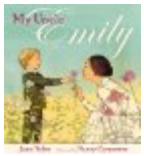
As census time approaches again, young readers will get a glimpse into how complicated it was for the tallymen to take the first census in 1790 by reading this very entertaining book. Poor Phineas Bump, who is very anxious to get home after being on the road so long that he's "heartsick, saddle-sore, and down on his luck," is hard-pressed to get the people of Tunbridge to cooperate with him in his efforts to count them all. The aptly named Peppers, Gripes, Swindles and others in the town do their best to outsmart Phineas, but he wins their cooperation through his determination and wit. Schindler's detailed illustrations add much to the humorous tale and give insights into Vermont life in the late 1700s. The illustration of the now burgeoning Swindle household with their 22 children (not all of them human!) will have children laughing at the foolishness. While teachers will be happy to include such a good explanation of the origins of the census and why it is important in their classrooms, students will simply enjoy the good story.

*Uncle Andy's Cats* by James Warhola.
Putnam. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399251804




Recounted from childhood memories of James Warhola, Pop Art guru Andy Warhol's nephew, this book gives an interesting snapshot from a child's point of view of Andy Warhol's easygoing lifestyle and his love for cats. As a child, James remembered visiting his Uncle Andy's house and his many cats, which were all named "Sam" because they all looked like their dad Sam. The Sams were adorable and playful, yet it was still a problem for the artist and his mother to have so many in their small apartment. Children will enjoy their solution to the problem. Readers may recognize many of Andy Warhol's artworks that were initially just a part of the artist's daily life. This book is a touching homage to James' favorite Uncle Andy!

*Uncle Emily* by Jane Yolen, Nancy Carpenter (Illustrator).
Philomel Books. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 0399240055



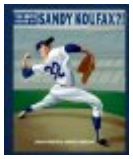

Through sharing one poetic anecdote about the day that young Gib, whose Uncle Emily (the "uncle" being a family joke) is Emily Dickinson, delivers a dead bee and tiny poem to his teacher and fights a bully to defend his Uncle Emily's honor, Yolen not only casts a light on the reclusive poet but also on how poets think and why they write. There is a great deal of truth to the fictionalized, biographical story, as Yolen explains in a note at the end of the book, which is only appropriate since the poet believed in telling the truth, though not always directly: "Tell the Truth but tell it slant -" she encourages her troubled nephew. Carpenter's delicately colored pen and ink illustrations capture the poet's beauty and her glorious garden, along with young Gib's varying emotions over what happened in his 19th century classroom.

*White Noise* by David A. Carter.
Little Simon. 2009. Unpaged. $22.99. Informational Arts. Primary/Intermediate. 0. 1416940944




In this fifth and last book in his Color Series, Carter plays with the idea of white noise, with white shapes (some of which are somewhat hidden) creating all kinds of noises as each page is turned. There are also elements from his other books to discover. No one can resist turning the pages to admire each of his clever, abstract creations done in bold primary colors. No one can resist reading aloud the clever phrases that accompany each sculpture. In an author's note, Carter shares the inspiration for his "Sierra Nevada chopsticks; readers are on their own to figure out who Sir Anthony and Munari are!

*You Never Heard of Sandy Koufax?* by Jonah Winter, Andrew Carrilho (Illustrator).
Schwartz and Wade Books. 2009. 40 pages. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Primary/Intermediate. Jewish-American. 0375837388




Most children probably will answer "no" to the title question, but because of the amazing lenticular cover art that recreates Koufax's pitching motion, they won't be able to resist learning more about him. Through the colorful voice and baseball lingo of an old-time Dodger's ball player who knew Koufax as well as anyone could, Winter shares stories of the enigmatic, Jewish pitcher who many consider to be one of the best who ever threw the ball. Carrilho's powerful illustrations capture his physical and mental prowess, historic determination and steely gaze. He also uses plenty of Dodger blue and touches of gold to highlight the magical field, the base path and Koufax's glove. Anyone who loves the game will be intrigued by this fascinating account of one of its greats.

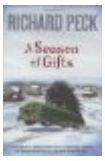
# Intermediate

*A Faraway Island* by Annika Thor, Linda Schenck (Translator).
Delacorte Press. 2009. 247 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. Europe (Scandinavia). 0385736177



When twelve-year-old Stephie Steiner and her seven-year-old sister, Nellie, are sent to Sweden to escape the Nazis, both are heartbroken and frightened. Finding themselves placed in two different families who live on an island off the western coast, both try to make the best of their difficult situation. While Nellie quickly settles into her new life with family and friends, Stephie's situation is different, as her "foster" mother keeps an emotional distance and the children at school are less than friendly. Themes of growing up, identity, and loss of family and country are heightened by the World War II setting.

*A Season of Gifts* by Richard Peck.
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. 164 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 0803730829



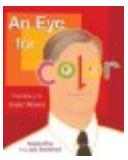

Though it is now the late 50's and Grandma Dowdel is quite elderly, she is still very much large and in charge with no time to be neighborly - though of course, she really is - to the preacher's family who has moved in next door. Twelve-year-old Bob confides that he's not very brave in the opening pages of the book, which makes his encounter with the town bullies all the more harrowing. Luckily, Grandma Dowdel comes to his rescue and nevers divulges his humiliation. She's a self-sufficient force of nature whose presence affects the entire town. Peck's latest story featuring this most amazing woman is truly a gift both to readers who thoroughly enjoyed his earlier award-winning books featuring the fearless grandmother, **A Long Way from Chicago** and **A Year Down Yonder**, and to those who haven't met this most amazing character before. Timeless insights gained into human behavior and what it means to be a true friend won't soon be forgotten.

*Adventures in Cartooning* by Alexis Frederick-Frost, Andrew Arnold, James Sturm.
First Second. 2009. 110 pages. $12.95. Informational Arts. Intermediate. 0. 1596433698



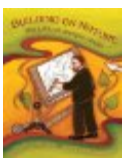
This is the perfect book for those who not only love to read comics but dream about creating their own comic book stories. "Once upon a time...a princess tried to make a comic..." Luckily for her, the Magic Cartooning Elf appears to help her discover how panels and word bubbles work, along with other useful tips. The humorous adventure story the princess creates will also have readers laughing all the way to the surprise happy ending (well, happy for everyone involved other than the sobbing dragon). Sure to be a favorite book in any classroom or library.

*An Eye for Color: The Story of Josef Albers* by Natasha Wing, Julia Breckenreid (Illustrator).
Henry Holt & Company. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. 0. 0805080724




This lively book gives a chronological overview of German-born American artist Josef Albers' entire life. As a son of a German handyman, Albers' initial exposure to art was through his father's work painting doors, which also inspired him to create different combinations of color squares, his signature art style. In his thirties, Albers received training in art at Bauhaus School of Design. When it was closed by the Nazis, he left Germany and came to America. Wing captures Albers' unique perspective on and passion for color, and Breckenreid's illustrations are clearly recognizable as an imitation of his unique painting style. The author's note gives readers a special insider view on Albers as a renowned artist and an amiable neighbor. The glossary of art terms is helpful to children who are interested in knowing more about color theory.

*Building on Nature: The Life of Antoni Gaudi* by Rachel Rodriguez, Julie Paschkis (Illustrator).
Henry Holt & Company. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Europe (Western). 0805087451



This biography of the famous Spanish architect Antoni Gaudi gives readers a chronological tour of Gaudi's life and works. Born in 1852, Gaudi was the son of a metal smith who grew up in the beautiful natural scenery of Catalonia, Spain. When he later finished his art training in Barcelona and became an architect, his childhood experiences as an artisan's apprentice and passion for nature came to play an important role

in shaping his Art Nouveau architecture style that is infused with curlicue decorations and floral patterns. As Gaudi put wilder and wilder imagination into his work on many architectural projects, he received polemic comments from critics of his time. Some despised his Modernist architectural style, whereas others were amazed by his groundbreaking designs. Well-developed text and colorful illustrations highlight the features of Gaudi's unconventional designs for young readers. The book would be a good art education resource for classroom use.

*Butterflies and Moths* by Nic Bishop.
Scholastic. 2009. 48 pages. $17.99. Informational Science. Intermediate. 0. 0439877571




Just as he has done with frogs and spiders in his previous books, through his often magnified photos and descriptive text, Nic Bishop gives young readers great insights into the lives of these ethereal creatures who have much in common. From the opening pages where fluttery dotted lines connect photos of a mourning cloak butterfly with those of silkworm and hummingbird moths, to the brightly colored (blue for the blue morpho butterfly), bolded text highlighting key passages, the design of the book enhances children's understanding of the important concepts explored. Bishop enlivens the information shared not only with his magnificent photographs, but with his vivid anecdotes, often sharing insights into the life of a naturalist as well. Children will be especially interested in why the photograph of the snakelike caterpillar who looms on pages 16-17 was so difficult to take. This is science writing and illustration at its best!

*Crows and Cards* by Joseph Helgerson.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. 352 pages. $16.00. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 0618883959



Times are tough in 1894 for twelve-year-old Zeb and his family. Sending him to St. Louis to apprentice with his uncle as a tanner seems to be the best solution. Too bad for Zeb that he's allergic to fur! No amount of arguing or complaining will change his parents' minds. On the riverboat Zeb meets a slick, smooth talking gambler who offers an alternative. Zeb accepts Chilly's offer to apprentice with him and is now headed for a life of gamblin', cheatin' and all around no-good. The folksy style of writing and abundance of quirky but charming characters make this tall tale a fun fast read from this Minnesota author.

*Django* by Bonnie Christensen.
Flash Point. 2009. Unpaged. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Europe (Western). 1596434228




This is an uplifting biography of the legendary Gypsy jazz guitarist Jean “Django” Reinhardt (1910-1953), who was born into poverty in a Gypsy encampment. Django had a passion for music and later learned to play banjo, guitar, and violin; his talent changed his life. Although his hands were badly burned in a fire and he was told by doctors that he would never be able to play guitar again, Django persevered and relearned to play the guitar. The captivating, impressionistic oil paintings really draw readers into the story. Christensen’s use of color successfully creates transitions of mood in the plot. An epilogue of Django’s life after he relearned the guitar gives readers a complete overview of his life and work.

*Eidi* by Bodil Bredsdorff, Kathryn Mahaffy (Translator).
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 138 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. Europe (Scandinavia). 0374312672



Eidi's cobbled-together family has come to live together in the little Danish cove and has grown by one, a new baby born to her mother, Foula, and her new husband. Eidi decides it's time to leave and find a place for herself in this survival story filled with cold, danger and other hardships but also with the warmth of loving relationships and honor. Readers who enjoyed **The Crow-Girl**, the first book in the Children of Crow Cove series, will relish the moving story of this forthright and resourceful girl who comes to the rescue of Tink, a young boy, abused by his stepfather. The sometimes surprising plot twists add to the drama.

*Everything for a Dog* by Ann M. Martin.
Feiwel & Friends. 2009. 211 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate. 0. 0312386516



In this book, Bone the dog (the brother of Squirrel from Martin's previous book, **A Dog's Life**) begins telling his story from his earliest memories and continues in alternating chapters narrated by two seemingly unrelated boys, Charlie and Henry. The three stories of love and loss and the need for friendship eventually are woven together to become one story. Martin does as fine a job conveying a dog's sensibilities as she

does in exploring the characteristics and emotional depths of the two sensitive boys and their families. There is plenty of dramatic tension throughout the book, building to a crescendo at the end. Even cat lovers won't be able to put the book down until the last page is turned.

*Extreme Scientists: Exploring Nature's Mysteries from Perilous Places* by Donna M. Jackson.
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 80 pages. $18.00. Informational Science. Intermediate. 0. 0618777067




The title alone should disabuse readers of the notion that all scientists wear white coats and work with test tubes in labs. The three scientists introduced in this latest addition to the **Scientists in the Field** series fly through hurricanes, dive deep into underwater caves and climb to the tops of redwoods over 300 feet tall. All risk their loves pursuing their scientific passions. Each shares how they first became interested as children in their particular fields, describes what they do at work, and answers some quick questions that readers would want to ask if they could meet these scientific daredevils. The fascinating text is accompanied by many photos that show just what these scientists do. A glossary of "Trailblazing Terms" is included for each, along with some interesting source notes describing the interviews and sharing more information about each scientist's credentials. The book is guaranteed to spark some readers' interests in scientific careers.

*Gertrude is Gertrude is Gertrude is Gertrude* by Jonah Winter, Calef Brown (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. 40 pages. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Europe (Western). 141694088X



This is a biographical story of the early 20th century American avant-garde writer Gertrude Stein, her salon in Paris that attracted famous modern art artists and writers of that time, including Picasso, Matisse and Hemingway, and her supportive relationship with her lifelong partner Alice B. Toklas. Winter ingeniously imitates the repetitive and experimental literary style that epitomizes Gertrude Stein's writing. Brown's vibrantly colored acrylic paintings similarly reflect and incorporate elements of Modern Art of the period, successfully contributing to the theme of this book. The book's title comes from Gertrude Stein's 1913 poem "Sacred Emily," in which she wrote: "Rose is a rose is a rose is a rose." The unruly spirit and groundbreaking modern literature pursuits of Gertrude Stein are rendered in quite an impressive way in this book.

*Heart of a Shepherd* by Rosanne Parry.
Random House Books for Young Readers. 2009. 176 pages. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 0375848029



When 11-year-old Brother is the last sibling left at the family ranch in eastern Washington, he feels responsible for everything. His father is in Iraq, his mother somewhere in Europe, and his older brothers either in the military or at boarding school. Trying to run the ranch with his elderly grandfather, grandmother, and a hired hand is a challenge, especially because he feels so immature as compared to the big boys. When a series of disasters strike, Brother learns how resilient he is. There are strong military and religious threads in this unusual coming-of-age story.

*January's Sparrow* by Patricia Polacco.
Philomel Books. 2009. 95 pages. $22.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. African-American. 0399250778




Polacco draws from true-to-life slave accounts to tell the first-person story of the Crosswhite family's journey from slavery on a Kentucky plantation to freedom in Marshall, Michigan. She captures the emotional toll of a life of slavery in the eyes of all the characters. Her drably shaded pencil and marker drawings reveal the deep sadness the Crosswhites feel living on the plantation at the hands of vindictive masters, just as the lighter colors and brighter patterns mark their freedom in Michigan. In the beginning of the book, January's reference to a small wooden sparrow, "It's fixin' to fly. And so is I," harkens to the hopefulness of the journey north, while also signaling fear at the uncertainty of what lies ahead. The same phrase spoken at the end of the book conveys a very different meaning. The book would be appropriate for anyone who loves dramatic stories about family, hope, and redemption.

*Letters to a Soldier* by Julie Hutt, David Falvey.
M. Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate. 0. 0761456376




This book is based on the correspondence between First Lieutenant David Falvey, who served in Iraq in 2008, and Julie Hutt's fourth-grade class in Roslyn, NY. Mrs. Hutt's students had various kinds of questions for David regarding military life and his service in Iraq. Children showed great curiosity and support in their personal letters to David, and David answered each question thoughtfully and with appreciation for their support. Photos of David while he was serving in Iraq give the book a genuine documentary look and an insider's view of one American soldier's life. Children, especially those with family members serving in the armed forces, may find connections with the students, David and his story and learn more about what it means to fight for your country.

*Lucky Breaks* by Susan Patron, Matt Phelan (Illustrator).
Atheneum Books. 2009. 176 pages. $18.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 1416939989



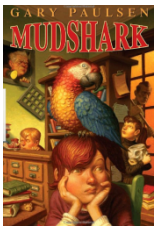
In this sequel to the Newbery Award winning **The Higher Power of Lucky,** Lucky is about to turn "flouncy e-lev-en" and is determined to be more intrepid than ever. In her quest for friendship (with characters Lincoln and Miles from the first book and a new possible female best friend, Paloma) and adventure, she makes some pretty bad choices. She deals with these mistakes with the wise help of her adoptive mother Brigitte and older friend Short Sammy and proves what it truly takes to be intrepid. Patron's creation of a realistic desert town inhabited by all sorts of interesting people and creatures gives readers a sense of the importance of community.

*Mermaid Queen: The Spectacular True Story Of Annette Kellerman, Who Swam Her Way To Fame, Fortune & Swimsuit History!* by Shana Corey, Edwin Fotheringham (Illustrator).
Scholastic Press. 2009. 48 pages. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Australia/New Zealand. 0439698359



Annette Kellerman was a legendary swimmer and the famous inventor of water ballet and swimsuits for women. Born on July 6, 1886, Annette was diagnosed with rickets when she was a child; to strengthen her leg muscles, she learned to swim and became a professional swimmer. The entire story highlights her perseverance, courage and innovations and contributions to her sport. The vibrant illustrations bring Annette and the early 1900s to life.

*Mud Shark* by Gary Paulsen.
Wendy Lamb Books. 2009. 83 pages. $12.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 038574685




Lyle Williams, aka Mudshark because of his athletic prowess revealed while playing Death Ball, is cool, really cool, and smart, really smart. He's faster than his wily toddler triplet sisters and able to solve all kinds of mysteries because of his powers of observation. Each chapter of this appealing, humorous story begins with the principal's intercom announcements concerning an increasingly dire situation in the faculty restroom (could anything be funnier?) and a missing gerbil and erasers (eventually gone from all the classrooms). Mudshark must outwit a busybody parrot - yes, a parrot - to save the custodian eraser thief (he had a very good reason for removing all of them). Guys will love reading about this talented, self-effacing guy, so they'll be glad when the principal proposes another mystery to solve on the last page. Mudshark has to be back!

*Neil Armstrong Is My Uncle & Other Lies Muscle Man McGinty Told Me* by Nan Marino.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. 154 pages. $16.95. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 1596434996




In Tamara's eyes, her new neighbor Muscle Man McGinty "is a squirrelly runt, a lying snake, and a pitiful excuse for a ten-year-old," and she belligerently sets out to convince the rest of the kids in her neighborhood of these truths. What she doesn't bargain for is how much she will learn about herself and why she is so angry in the process. Though the story takes place in 1969 - hence the reference to Neil Armstrong in the title—these characters, their personal problems and the neighborhood dynamics will seem quite contemporary to today's readers. Marino deftly mixes humor with the pathos to create a very engaging story

that will appeal to boys and girls alike.

*Noah Webster: Weaver of Words* by Pegi Deitz Shea, Monica Vachula (Illustrator).
Calkins Creek Books. 2009. 40 pages. $14.95. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. 0. 1590784413



A comprehensive and informative review of the life and work of Noah Webster, the "Schoolmaster to America," is presented in this engaging book. Born in 1758, Webster grew up during the time of the American Revolution and fostered a passion for languages and education. Webster committed himself to producing works such as textbooks and his famous dictionaries to promote literacy education; in addition, he was also a strong advocate of public schooling. The realistic illustrations done in oils give the book an old-time look that is reminiscent of the classical oil paintings of that era. The script on the endpapers is also a thoughtful link to the historic time period.

*Pharaoh's Boat* by David Weitzman.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. Unpaged. $18.00. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate. Africa (Northern). 054705341X




In his prologue, Weitzman reveals the puzzle facing workmen clearing away sand from the Great Pyramid at Giza in 1954. What secrets were hidden beneath a newly discovered stone boundary wall? He flashes back to the death of the pharaoh Cheops 4600 years before and to all the preparations that needed to be made to ensure his safe passage to the afterlife. After sharing details of the craftmanship of the long ago boat builders, the author then skillfully tells the modern story of Hag Ahmed Youssef Moustafa, the man responsible for restoring and recreating the boat that can now be seen by anyone visiting the pyramid. As the story of the creation and recreation of the boat progresses, Weitzman's artistic style changes from early Egyptian influenced drawings and hieroglyphs to more modern looking, yet equally detailed, drawings of the boat's reconstruction. The book will enthrall those readers interested in ancient Egypt and also those who love to know how things work.

*Racing Against the Odds: The Story of Wendell Scott, Stock Car Racing's African-American Champion* by Carole Boston Weatherford, Eric A. Velasquez (Illustrator).
M. Cavendish. 2009. 40 pages. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. African-American. 0761454659



Wendall Scott (1921-1990) was NASCAR's first winning African-American driver, although his winner's position was at first denied but later secretly awarded to him. Being a black driver whose racing heyday was from the 1940s to the 1970s, Wendall was frequently confronted by racial discrimination and often treated unfairly in races. On top of that, Wendall was never well-off enough to have a new car, nor was he ever sponsored by any promoters. However, his preeminent driving skills made him stand out among the drivers of his time, making him a winner on and off the track. The acrylic illustrations complete the down-to-earth tone of this book. Since racetracks provide most of the settings, the colors are often the subdued concrete grays contrasted with the brightly colored cars. The close-ups of race cars will bring readers vicariously to the track.

*Rumi: Persian Poet, Whirling Dervish* by Demi.
Marshall Cavendish. 2009. Unpaged. $19.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Asia (Middle East). 0761455272



This picture book illustrates the legendary life of the great Afghan mystical poet and whirling dervish, Mawlana Jalaladdin Rumi. Paying tribute to this great poet, the United Nations made 2007 The Year of Mawlana Jalaladdin Rumi. Rumi succeeded as an erudite scholar and theologist, showing seemingly endless poetic creativity while reciting more than 50,000 poems that not only praised God but also evoked his love of all humanity. The Islamic style illustrations overlaid with golden frames were a perfect compliment to the story. An author's note about Rumi precedes the beginning of the story and gives readers important background knowledge. Endpapers are printed with whirling dervishes, showing the dance that was Rumi's invention in order to pay homage to God.

*Saving the Ghost of the Mountain: An Expedition Among Snow Leopards in Mongolia* by Sy Montgomery, Nic Bishop (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. 74 pages. $18.00. Informational Science. Intermediate. Asia (Far East). 0618916458



This dynamic author/photographer team, who have collaborated on a number of other fascinating books in the **Scientists in the Field** series, joins Tom McCarthy, scientist and conservation director of the Snow Leopard Trust, in the remote mountains of Mongolia to document his decades-long research into the snow leopard. Besides gaining a great deal of insight into the elusive, rarely seen animal, readers will also appreciate the difficult but exhilarating scientific work and the culture of the Mongolian people who have come to tolerate the animals they once despised as predators who attacked their herds. The book is beautifully designed, with embellished letters, artistic photographs on every page, and numerous sidebars filled with interesting information. Notes written by both author and photographer tell about the difficulties of working and protecting equipment in the high Altai Mountains, giving readers an even greater appreciation of the information they share. Students who want to learn more about the books the author read, read her field diary, or see more of Bishop's photos are directed to their websites.

*Signal* by Cynthia DeFelice.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 151 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 0374399158




While running along the trail near his new home with his dog, Owen discovers some bloody cloth and eventually a mysterious, green-eyed girl who's been hit in the head and is covered with cuts. He has problems of his own since his mother has died, but nothing to compare to Cam's unbelievable story of having been "left behind" by her parents. Owen vows to help her solve her problem in a most unusual way and fiercely guards her location from the cruel man who's desperately looking for her. The fine pacing and warm-hearted friendship that develops between the two leads to a not-too-surprising, dramatic ending, considering the clues that have been left along the way.

*Strawberry Hill* by Mary Ann Hoberman, Wendy Anderson Halperin (Illustrator).
Little, Brown. 2009. 240 pages. $15.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. Jewish-American. 031604136X



Alice Sherman, known as Allie to her family and friends, does not really want to leave New Haven, her family's apartment, or her best friend Ruthie, but the lure of a place named Strawberry Hill in Stamford is enough to pique her anticipation of the move. In addition to a bedroom all to herself - decorated all in pink, no less - Allie learns to define real friendship in the midst of some trying experiences. She becomes a friend to Mimi, the lonely, often needy girl across the street, defends herself and her Jewish heritage to Cynthia, a spoiled rich girl, is befriended by another Alice/Allie at school, and decides what being a friend means through her experiences with Martha, her neighbor. Largely autobiographical, the novel tells the sweet story of a 4th grader's understanding of her place in the world and in her family's life. Enhanced by the charming artwork of Wendy Anderson Halperin, the book will be enjoyed by young readers for its glimpse at a time period in the not-so-distant past.

*The Beef Princess of Practical County* by Michelle Houts.
Delacorte Books for Young Readers. 2009. 240 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate. 0. 0385735847



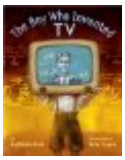
When Libby undertakes the task of raising two calves to show in the Practical County fair, her father warns her against naming--and coming to love--the animals. Of course, she does just that, and when the calf she loved the most and planned to show is injured, she is devastated. She's the daughter of an Indiana cattleman, and she knows what happens to steers. Embedded in this story of her quest for a blue ribbon is a strong coming-of-age theme as Libby also enters the contest for the fair princess and begins to notice one particular boy. She does everything, even buying her princess dress, with her own distinctive style, and it is from these same core strengths that she can accept a ribbon along with the inevitable loss of her steer at the end of the fair. Laughter and tears accompany the reading of this book by a new voice for young readers.

*The Blue Shoe: A Tale of Thievery, Villainy, Sorcery, and Shoes* by Roderick Townley, Mary GrandPre (Illustrator).
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. 255 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate. 0. 0375856005



After young Hap is imprisoned by the cruel mayor and sent to his probable death inside the the icy Mount Xexnax from which no one ever returns, all seems lost to everyone but the ever-optimistic Hap. The reader is warned: "You will have noticed our story has taken a darker turn. It's likely to get darker yet." And indeed it does. Hap eventually saves his father, finds out the secret to the mysterious stranger who has paid for the jewel-encrusted shoe coveted by the mayor and his greedy wife, and rejoices with the townspeople and the Aukis, a mountain race enslaved by the evil mayor and his minions, in the return of the goddess Xexnax. Mythical and traditional folkloric elements, including the magic shoe, the humble shoemaker, and a boy who goes off on a heroic quest, are woven throughout the exciting adventure. As in all good folktales, evil and vanity are punished, while good deeds are justly rewarded.

*The Boy Who Invented TV: The Story of Philo Farnsworth* by Kathleen Krull, Greg Couch (Illustrator).
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. 0. 0375845615



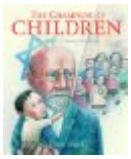
Krull deftly describes life at the turn of the last century when Farnsworth was a child and young man in Utah with just-right anecdotes that highlight his inventive prowess and genius and the ah-ha moment when he finally figured out a way to transmit picture images. Couch's illustrations, including the endpapers' history of television design from the earliest models to today's flat screens, provide plenty of details about the setting and the young man's invention that changed how the world was viewed. Both give a sense of who this man was, appropriately ending his story for a young audience with the announcement of his new invention at the age of 22. In her author's note, Krull describes his long-time battle for patent rights with RCA and explains why he never became as famous as other American inventors such as Thomas Edison. This is a well told, inspiring story that many television lovers will relish.

*The Case of the Cryptic Crinoline* by Nancy Springer.
Philomel Books. 2009. 176 pages. $14.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate. Great Britain. 0399247815



The fifth book in this spirited series features precocious Enola Holmes, the 14-year-old sister of Sherlock and Mycroft Holmes. Enola, currently living on her own in London, begins to investigate when her landlady is kidnapped. Enola discovers a connection in the form of Morse Code between a crinoline owned by her landlady and the work of Florence Nightingale during the Crimean War. Enola must solve the mystery and rescue her landlady while dodging her older brothers who want to send her to a dreadful boarding school. Those who already enjoy the Enola Holmes mysteries will love this latest addition, while those who are reading Nancy Springer's mysteries for the first time will rush to pick up the rest of them to discover what they have been missing.

*The Champion of Children: The Story of Janusz Korczak* by Tomek Bogacki.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 40 pages. $17.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Europe (Eastern). 0374341362




The story of Janusz Korczak, a well-known Polish-Jewish doctor, writer, and advocate for children's rights, is told from his birth in 1878 to his death in an extermination camp with children from his orphanage in 1942. Janusz Korczak had devoted himself to establishing and running orphanages that gave orphans the same kind of warm care he had as a child and felt they deserved. The depictions of Korczak and the children and somber tones of the acrylic illustrations help to tell the touching story of a remarkable man who lived during the darkest Holocaust history of Europe during World War II.

*The Daring Miss Quimby* by Suzanne Whitaker, Catherine Stock (Illustrator).
Holiday House. 2009. Unpaged. $16.95. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. 0. 0823419967



Courageous Harriet Quimby was not only a professional magazine writer but also the first woman in the United States to receive her pilot's license. The story constantly accentuates her daring deeds, from her coverage of a car race, to her initially failed attempt to obtain her pilot's license, to her great success when she completed a solo flight across the English Channel. Her tragic death caused by her last flight over Boston Harbor brings this uplifting biography to a sad end, however the last paragraph

acknowledges Harriet's pioneering spirit that has inspired many adventurous aviatrixes who followed her daring lead. The vivid illustrations succeed in creating an uplifting atmosphere for the story as they also share many historical details from the time period. The purple endpapers echo Harriet's one-of-a-kind, purple flight suit.

*The East-West House: Noguchi's Childhood in Japan* by Christy Hale.
Lee & Low Books. 2009. Unpaged. $17.95. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Bicultural. 1600603637



Born in America to a mother of British heritage and a Japanese father, Isamu Noguchi was raised in Japan, where he never quite fit in because of his biracial heritage and his remarkable artistic talents. As he explored Japan with his Western mother, he was entranced with the shapes and colors of the natural world. As he matured, he used the natural forms that he found so beautiful to create a home for himself and his mother and, eventually, his sculptures, a blend between East and West, just like himself. Extensive endnotes add to the information about this remarkable artist.

*The Frog Scientist* by Pamela S. Turner, Andy Comins (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. 58 pages. $18.00. Informational Science. Intermediate. African-American. 0618717161



While this latest book in the highly regarded **Scientists in the Field** series introduces students to how a biologist poses a question and sets up experiments to find the answer, it also introduces them to Tyrone Hayes, a brilliant and non-stereotypical, African-American scientist, his family and his enthusiastic group of graduate students. Even as a child growing up in segregated Columbia, South Carolina, Hayes was fascinated by the frogs and other aquatic life in the swamp near his home. Through sharing his story, Turner shows students how their own interests can become careers through education and perseverance. And then there are the close-up photos of frogs, the other stars of this book, whose wide eyes stare at readers, imploring them to discover all their secrets and why so many of their species are endangered or extinct. It's impossible for readers to resist such a well-designed book and well-told story. This is science writing at its best.

*The Name Game: A Look Behind the Labels* by Donna M. Jackson, Ted Stearn (Illustrator).
Viking. 2009. 64 pages. $16.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate. Multicultural. 0670011975



Everyone has one and is interested in them, so this book about names - their origins, oddities and other interesting facts - has universal appeal. The light-hearted tone of Jackson's writing is enhanced by Stearn's comic illustrations, including those of children named Pleasant Lee and Preserved Wood, the myriad women named Grace Lee, and sports stars nicknamed Hammerin' Hank or The Refrigerator. Wanting information about your own name or need to find a great name for a new sibling or pet? Jackson lists many websites and other books on the subject.

*The Secret of Zoom* by Lynne Jonell.
Henry Holt & Company. 2009. 291 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate. 0. 0805088563



The Adnoids (yes, there's plenty of wordplay to be found) are scientists who are tragically lured to work at Loompski Labs, a darkly Gothic place now run by a Dickensian villain (there are plenty of abused orphans too) whose much more talented and benign brother has been missing as long as Christina Adnoid's mother has been supposedly dead, blown up in a lab accident so horrible that there was nothing left of her. The plot, with its mysteries and discoveries, zooms along so quickly that young readers won't want to put the book down. Though evil looms large and there are edge-of-your-seat plot turns, good does most certainly prevail in the end. Students and teachers will enjoy the scenes where true education, not computerized drudgery with happy chicken encouragement, is applauded.

*Trains* by Lynn Curlee.
Atheneum Books. 2009. 40 pages. $19.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate. 0. 1416948481



Along with many other enthusiasts, Curlee grew up admiring trains in his North Carolina hometown that came into being because of the railroad. He deftly shows how the country's history - from westward expansion to the Union winning the Civil War because of their more extensive railroads and beyond - and the history of the railroad are intertwined. His geometric, acrylic illustrations in steely blues and warm browns emphasize the majesty of the machines with their huge engines, sleek cars and

rumbling wheels. He ends the book with a double-page spread with a cutaway illustration explaining how a steam locomotive works. Curlee's clear prose tells the engaging story of trains in similar fashion to what he has done for other interesting topics: skyscrapers, ballparks, and airships among them.

*Tutankhamun* by Demi.
Marshall Cavendish. 2009. 64 pages. $19.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. Africa (Northern). 0761455582



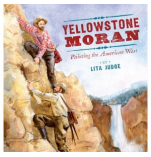

Through Demi's deft storytelling and impressive artwork, King Tutankhamun and his physical and political worlds in ancient Egypt come to life over 3200 years after his mysterious and untimely death. Gilded images of the man and important people and events in his life are inspired by Egyptian art, architecture and jewelry and are set against a pale linen background. His secret tomb was the only one that had never been discovered, so all of its treasures remained intact. Demi dazzles readers with her version of the statue enclosing his mummy. She also includes a map of the region and a family tree.

*Whaling Season: A Year in the Life of an Arctic Whale Scientist* by Peter Lourie.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. 80 pages. $18.00. Informational Science. Intermediate. Inuit. 0618777091




Another fine addition to the fascinating Scientist in the Field series, this book focuses on one expedition of the Arctic whale scientist John Craighead George (son of author Jean Craighead George), who has studied bowhead whales for more than 30 years. The often dramatic scenes in this book were photographed in Barrow, Alaska, where John, or Craig as he's called, works with the local Inupiaq whale hunters to conduct his studies, combining their traditional knowledge with his modern scientific research methods. This book demonstrates the old whaling traditions of Inupiaq Eskimos by describing hunter knowledge, the Inupiaq hunters' respect for the whales, and also illuminating Inupiaq community life. John Craighead George is also profiled so that readers learn about his scientific background as well as his more laidback side: he plays electric guitar for amusement. The photos and insights provide a vicarious experience of the whale scientist's life. The book is also a good resource for information about whales, whaling, and the Inupiaq society.

*Yellowstone Moran: Painting the American West* by Lita Judge.
Viking. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate. 0. 0670011320




American landscape painter Thomas Moran (1837-1926) was never a big fan of outdoor adventure and enjoyed the comfort of a civilized life. Yet in 1871, he decided to join a scientific expedition to Yellowstone, an unexplored land full of sulfur pools, precipitous cliffs, and ferocious wildlife at that time. Moran captured the magnificent landscape in his now famous paintings which helped persuade the US Congress to make Yellowstone the country's first national park. The text is narrated in a conversational style using Moran's journals that detail his adventures. The book's illustrations imitate Moran's style of painting, showing the grandeur that Moran saw then and that we can still enjoy today.

# Intermediate/Adolescent

*3 Willows: The Sisterhood Grows* by Ann Brashares.
Delacorte Press. 2009. 318 pages. $18.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0385736762



Using the metaphor of the seeds, roots and leaves of the willow, Brashares tells the story of three younger sisterhood girls, once close friends who have now grown apart, the summer before they begin high school. The episodic presentation of each of their difficult summer stories is at times melodramatic but always entertaining for the intended audience of the younger sisters of those who read about the original sisterhood, the young women who shared the "traveling pants." Do they eventually realize how much they still care about and need each other? Of course!

*A Savage Thunder: Antietam and the Bloody Road to Freedom* by Jim Murphy.
Margaret K. McElderry Books. 2009. 103 pages. $17.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0689876335




Murphy's choice of a title is quite apt for this account of the bloodiest day of battle in U.S. history. He balances his telling with gripping, first-hand accounts of the battle from soldiers of both ill-fated armies and with insights into the two generals - Lee and McClellan - on whom these men's fates rested. Archival photos and drawings, including those of the battle's aftermath, give further insight into the horrors of war, especially one ironically named the Civil War. Because of Brady's stunning photos, for the first time people not on the battle field could see what was happening. One particularly poignant photo shows a stark, leafless tree, a few soldiers, and a lone grave. As in all of his other books, Murphy's prodigious research is evident throughout the engaging text.

*Al Capone Shines My Shoes* by Gennifer Choldenko.
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. 288 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0803734603



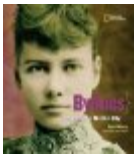

Choldenko does not disappoint her readers with the sequel to the Newbery Honor award-winning book **Al Capone Does My Shirts**. The story picks up where the other one left off: Moose's sister is going off to a boarding school on the mainland...thanks to the help of one Al Capone. After Natalie is gone, Moose finds another note in his laundry that just says, "Your Turn." Follow Moose on an adventure around the island where he tries to stay one step ahead of his friends, family, and, of course, the convicts. According to Moose, “On Alcatraz, heaven is across from hell.”

*All the Broken Pieces* by Ann E. Burg.
Scholastic Press. 2009. 219 pages. $16.99. Poetry. Intermediate/Adolescent. Multicultural. 0545080924




The Viet Nam War has ended a few years earlier, and Matt, whose mother is Vietnamese and father is an American soldier who left and never returned, is one of the fortunate yet haunted children who has been airlifted to a new life and loving family in America. His past is revealed in flashes in this fluid, well paced, free verse novel, as Matt deals with prejudice in school and on the baseball field and his own guilt about what happened to his brother while he was in charge. Though the story is told in first person by Matt, Burg shows how the war has wounded many others, giving insight into many other perspectives. The ending is realistic and satisfying; even though life is better for Matt and those closest to him, all the broken pieces haven't been neatly mended yet.

*Bylines: A Photobiography of Nellie Bly* by Sue Macy.
National Geographic Society. 2009. 64 pages. $19.95. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1426305133



At a time when most women cared for homes and children rather than join the work force, Elizabeth Seaman, better known as Nellie Bly, took great risks and went on an around-the-world trip as an intrepid young reporter. Macy interestingly catalogues all that she accomplished in her lifetime and shows how

she fought conventional notions of who women and journalists were. There are many entertaining highlights and anecdotes to illuminate America at the turn of the last century through the lens of the most famous journalist of the period. As foretold by the title, every turn of the page includes photos and other memorabilia that also bring Nelly Bly and her time to life.

*Claudette Colvin: Twice Toward Justice* by Philip Hoose.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 121 pages. $19.95. Biography/Memoir. Intermediate/Adolescent. African-American. 0374313229




Claudette Colvin's compelling story of fighting the injustice of the segregated Montgomery bus system after being arrested for refusing to give up her seat to a white woman months before Rosa Parks did, highlights the evils of Jim Crow laws and the bravery of those willing to take a stand. Hoose has brought the courageous teenager's story to the forefront after she had all but disappeared from history, even though she was one of four witnesses whose stories helped to integrate public transportation through their eventual Supreme Court victory in Browder v. Gayle. Hoose narrates her story but also includes many excerpts from the extensive interviews he conducted with Claudette Colvin while gathering material to flesh out the details of the person and the act that was so important in triggering the civil rights movement. Besides the interviews, his thorough research is also evident in the chapter notes and acknowledgments included at the end of the book. Black and white photos of segregated Montgomery buses, Colvin, Martin Luther King, Jr. and others involved in the bus boycott help to bring the time period to life.

*Crazy beautiful* by Lauren Baratz-Logsted.
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 191 pages. $16.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0547223072



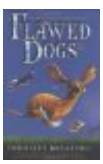
When Lucius blew his hands off in a crazy, homemade experiment, the explosion also destroyed the family home. He chose metal hooks because they were cheaper, and he would not outgrow them so quickly. After the explosion his family moved to a new town, and Lucius started his sophomore year at a new high school. He put on an “I don’t care attitude” and tried to move through his days unnoticed. But Aurora noticed him and wasn’t frightened or repulsed by his hooks. When Lucius heard that Aurora would be auditioning for the school play, he did too, hoping to get to know her better. Lucius became the stage manager and now must confront his own demons as he moved out of his comfort zone. Told in both Aurora’s and Lucius’ voices, this Beauty and the Beast twist is compelling and gripping. Readers will learn along with Lucius how the power of redemption can change an individual.

*Demon's Lexicon* by Sarah Rees Brennan.
Margaret K. McElderry Books. 2009. 336 pages. $17.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. Great Britain. 1416963790



Nick Ryves and his brother Alan have only known a life on the run. It seems as soon as they get settled in one place, magicians find them, and they have to move again. This has been their life since their father was murdered and their mother was driven mad by demons. But now Alan is marked for death, and their whereabouts can easily be traced through Alan’s mark. Nick and Alan decide to put the future in their own hands and set out to find the magicians' lair in London in order to force a magician to clear Alan. As they scheme and plan, Nick discovers that Alan has been lying to him his whole life. Who is Nick really and why does Alan treat him so kindly? Their plan to find and kill a magician backfires when the magicians outsmart the duo and their two friends. Nick must face his family’s dark secrets and try and save the only family he has known. This fast paced, page-turning novel will keep readers’ attention to the very last page.

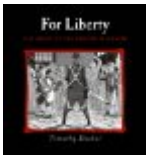
*Flawed Dogs* by Berkeley Breathed.
Philomel Books. 2009. 216 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0399252185




The adventures of Sam the dog are at times quite humorous while at other times harrowing. Told in the first person by Sam, his story begins when he's carried into a place that's "empty of heat and kindness" to fight but instead faces death by laying on his side, closing his eyes and flashing back to a much happier time. How Sam goes from expensive show dog, so loved by the young orphan Heidy, to the National Last-Ditch Dog Depository, filled with a motley assortment of abandoned dogs, and finally to the Westminster Dog Show to seek his revenge is a fast-paced, over-the-top tale that certainly doesn't fit the norm of the true-blue,

man's-best-friend dog story. Breathed's occasional black and white and full-color illustrations add depth to the exaggerated characters and situations. The book will appeal to readers who miss Bloom County and Breathed's inspired sense of humor.

*For Liberty: The Story of The Boston Massacre* by Timothy Decker.
Calkins Creek Books. 2009. 40 pages. $17.95. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1590786084




With illustrations in a black-and-white, cross-hatched style, **For Liberty** allows readers to revisit March 5th, 1770, the day of the historic tragedy of the Boston Massacre. The story is told in a somewhat emotionally detached and calm tone that gives a documentary feeling. The conflict between the American colonists and the British soldiers that finally led to a bloody massacre is presented in a balanced manner, giving readers both perspectives in order to view the tragedy more objectively. The artistic elements are also outstanding – from the special style of the typeface that is similar to the kind of font often seen in the 18th century documents, to the gloomy and strange atmosphere created by the depictions of the expressionless characters with their strange eyes. This book would be a good supporting resource for students who are learning about American colonial history.

*Franny Parker* by Hannah Roberts McKinnon.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 149 pages. $16.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0374324697




In this debut novel, the author has created characters the reader will genuinely care about. She also has a way with words that perceptive readers will relish. The story is set in a small Oklahoma town that is experiencing one of the worst droughts since the 1930s. Thirteen-year-old Franny spends a considerable amount of her time nursing injured wildlife back to good health. When a single mom and her son, who is about Franny's age, move in next door to the Parkers, life becomes more complex. Even though this period develops into a very difficult time in her life, it also proves to be very rewarding. In her acknowledgements, the author thanks her Enlish teacher for encouraging her to write. Both of them can be very proud of this first book. Readers will look forward to seeing more from her in the future.

*I Heard God Talking To Me: William Edmondson and His Stone Carvings* by Elizabeth Spires.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 64 pages. $17.95. Poetry. Intermediate/Adolescent. African-American. 0374335281




As the first African-American sculptor to have a solo exhibition at the Museum of Modern Art in New York, William Edmondson had a unique, folksy artistic style. Edmondson, an ordinary plantation worker, one day answered God's call and began making his sculptures. His works are chunky, primitive, and present the bold, unconstrained beauty of rocks. Black and white photos of the artist and many of his works accompany Elizabeth Spires' revealing, biographical poetry, often written from Edmondson's perspective and using some of his own words, to highlight his artistic life and relationship with God. These poems give readers an authentic glimpse of William Edmondson's work, and perhaps of utmost importance to this artist, his faith in, and inspiration from, God.

*Jasper Dash and the Flame-Pits of Delaware* by M.T. Anderson, Kurt Cyrus (Illustrator).
Beach Lane Books. 2009. 423 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1416986391




Jasper Dash, Boy Technonaut, and his two side-kick "chums", Lily and Katie, are off to exotic Delaware (yes, Delaware!), a land of jungles and misty mountains that's so poor that they can't afford many vowels in their language. While unceasingly chasing and battling evil villains in the aid of mystical, non-violent monks, they overcome one danger after another to the triumphant ending. Anderson has a great deal of fun in this parody of earlier boys series adventures and sports novels (Jasper is the most talented member of his high school's varsity stare-eyes team) while also poking fun at tourists and their guidebooks along the way. Every once in a while, he speaks directly to the reader about what he's up to, adding another level of humor to the fantastic tale. Cyrus's black and white detailed illustrations add to the fast-paced adventure while also harkening back in style to earlier children's book illustrators. Another book in the **Pals in Peril Tale** series.

*Just One Wish* by Janette Rallison.
G.P. Putnam's Sons. 2009. 264 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0399246185




Rallison's fans will find this book somewhat different from her others. The main character, a caring and passionate teenager, manages to fulfill a wish for her cancer-ridden little brother. The story swings back and forth between seriously tender scenes and absurdly outlandish predicaments. Through her efforts to make her brother happy, she discovers important lessons regarding her own happiness--and the purpose of life.

*Lucy Long Ago: Uncovering the Mystery of Where We Came From* by Catherine Thimmesh, Oscar Sanisidro (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 63 pages. $18.00. Informational Science. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0547051999



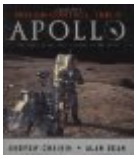

With the discovery of 47 fossilized bones from a small hominid - later named Lucy - who lived a few million years ago in what is now Ethiopia, came a new theory of human evolution, as Thimmesh so eloquently discusses in her latest inquiry into how science is done. By illuminating the paths of the researchers and including sections titled "And the Bones Said," she ably shows how the work of many different scientists leads to new answers to age-old questions and tells a fascinating story using literary language in the process. The many photos and illustrations included in the book highlight important ideas, but it is the direct, piercing gaze of Paleo-artist John Gurche's life-size, highly realistic sculpture of Lucy that will give readers pause when they first see the cover. You are compelled to read Lucy's story, to see what mystery has been resolved because of her. The long list of acknowledgements and resources at the end of the books is a testament to the author's considerable research on the subject.

*Marching for Freedom: Walk Together, Children, Don't You Grow Weary* by Elizabeth Partridge.
Viking. 2009. 72 pages. $19.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. African-American. 0670011894




What sets this well-researched and fascinating account of the Selma voting rights protests apart from many other books about the Civil Rights Movement is Partridge's focus on the children and teens who courageously stood up to those who would deny African-American adults the right to vote. Along with the young protesters' day-by-day, first-hand descriptions of the struggle, there are many compelling, well selected, black and white photos that show the determination of those seeking their rights and the hatred and violence of those in opposition to them. The right to vote: "So simple. So powerful." Extensive source notes and bibliography are included.

*Mission Control, This Is Apollo: The Story of the First Voyages to the Moon* by Victoria Kohl, Andrew Chaikin, Alan Bean (Illustrator).
Viking. 2009. 114 pages. $23.99. Informational Science. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0670011568




From its elegant design, to its lavish illustrations, both photos and paintings by former astronaut and moonwalker Alan Bean, and fine, factual storytelling, often including astronauts' annecdotes, this timely overview of the Apollo program commands attention. Chaikin's abundant research and experience with the space program over the last 25 years is quite obvious, as is his love of space exploration. In addition to his accomplished and dramatic artwork, Bean's personal memories in captions throughout the book and information about his paintings in a note at the end add a great deal of insight to this comprehensive history. Space lovers of all ages will be fascinated by the book.

*Mr. Lincoln's High-Tech War* by Thomas B. Allen, Roger McBride Allen.
National Geographic Society. 2009. 144 pages. $18.95. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1426303793




While there are many other books about the Civil War available, the Allens give adolescent readers a different perspective on why the North ultimately won. The new surge of technology that began with Lincoln's birth and accelerated through the 1800's was embraced by the president and was crucial to the outcome of many battles. Boxes inserted in the text give added information about the development

and impact of different inventions successfully used by the North. The well designed and engaging book also includes many photos and drawings from the time, along with an extensive bibliography for those interested in researching the topic further.

*Notes from the Dog* by Gary Paulsen.
Wendy Lamb Books. 2009. 132 pages. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0385738455




The summer that his truest friend Matthew stays with him and his Dad, and he meets Johanna, his grad student next door neighbor who's fighting breast cancer, fourteen-year-old Finn soon learns that having company can be life changing. Finn knows that it's Johanna who gives his dog Dylan the life affirming notes to bring to him, and it's his relationship with her that gives him the courage to have a relationship with Karla, the girl he's so obviously pining over. While this is a tender coming of age story, there's still plenty of Paulsen humor, especially because of Finn's gardening exploits. Paulsen dedicates the book "with all respect and hope to everyone who has ever faced cancer." His story is one of triumph and hope, though the epilogue hints that Johanna lost her battle.

*Return to Sender* by Julia Alvarez.
Knopf Books for Young Readers. 2009. 336 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. Latino-American. 0375858385




This novel, named for a U.S. immigration program, is told in the alternating voices of Tyler and Mari. Tyler, a 6th grade boy living on a small farm in Vermont, learns of the problems undocumented workers face in the U.S. when Mari's family comes to help at the farm. Mari's father and uncle work the farm while they all await word from her mother, who returned to Mexico to care for Mari's grandmother, and has not been heard from for a year. Each chapter, numbered in both Spanish and English, has a title that refers to the growing seasons.

*Slob* by Ellen Potter.
Philomel Books. 2009. 208 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 039924705X




Owen, a brilliant teen inventor, has several problems, not the least of which is that someone keeps stealing the Oreos from his lunch. In addition to inventing traps to catch the culprit, Owen is working on a long-term project to recover a video of the events that changed his life years earlier. With his supportive, but strange, younger sister and mom, he uncovers shocking surprises about his family and himself.

*Smoke* by Mavis Jukes.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 164 pages. $16.95. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0374370850



Smoke is a twenty-pound, jet-black cat who is dearly loved by his twelve-year-old owner, Colton Hudson. When Colt and his mom move to northern California, there are many adjustments he has to make--and he's pretty unhappy about the move. He misses his Grandpa Hudson and his father, who lives life dangerously on the rodeo circuit. When Smoke disappears one night, his emotions are put to the test. The tension mounts as Colt makes some questionable choices. Mavis Jukes has crafted a tender story with characters that are caring, candid, and comforting.

*Sweethearts of Rhythm: The Story of the Greatest All-Girl Swing Band in the World* by Marilyn Nelson, Jerry Pinkney (Illustrator).
Dial Books. 2009. Unpaged. $21.99. Poetry. Intermediate/Adolescent. African-American. 0803731876



In poetry as rhythmic as the swing music she writes about, Nelson tells the 1940's history of the International Sweethearts of Rhythm through the voices of the women's instruments. When describing their USO tour: "Our quicksilver swing proved a reawakening:/ Lots of uniformed men learned again how to smile." Readers can't help but smile as they sway through the poems that should be read aloud.

Enthusiastic dancers swish across the pages and notes float in the air in the evocative watercolor illustrations that capture the musicians, their audiences and the era so well. A chronology and photo of the Sweethearts and notes from the poet and illustrator give further historical information; the bibiliography includes films and recordings along with printed resources.

*The Beautiful Stories of Life: Six Greek Myths, Retold* by Cynthia Rylant, Carson Ellis (Illustrator).
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 71 pages. $16.00. Folk Literature. Intermediate/Adolescent. Europe (Mediteranian). 0152061843




Rylant wholeheartedly agrees with Psyche "that the most beautiful story of life is love," and so she has selected myths that deal with love in its many guises. She lyrically retells these well know stories and makes them her own. She explores vanity, loss, and the bad decisions made because of love. Ellis's classically influenced black and white illustrations highlight the most important details of the characters and settings of these moving, well chosen stories.

*The Books of Umber: Happenstance Found* by P.W. Catanese.
Aladdin. 2009. 342 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1416975195



Catanese fills this first book in the series with rich and well-developed characters and a sizable world filled with many races, wonders, and dimensions. “The boy felt as if he’d emerged…out of nothing." Happenstance, or Hap for short, has no memory of who he is or where he came from. When a mysterious man leaves him with many unanswered questions, he is soon found by a man named Lord Umber. Catanese weaves an interesting tale of fantasy around Hap’s quest to find out who he is…and why Lord Umber wants to keep him close.

*The Day of the Pelican* by Katherine Paterson.
Clarion Books. 2009. 139 pages. $16.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. Europe (Eastern). 0547181884



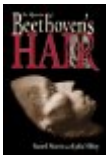
Soon after Meli and her Albanian family living in Kosovo hear of nearby Serbian atrocities, they are forced to flee for their lives. After a great deal of hardship and a seemingly endless time living in a refugee camp, she and her family become American immigrants. Paterson gives readers a realistic look at the difficulties of leaving home and trying to establish new lives in a strange place where you don't speak the language or understand the customs. The most difficult challenges come after the attacks on 9/11 when Meli and her older brother Mehmet are attacked at school as "terrorists" because of their Muslim religion. Hatred and intolerance come in many guises, even in the United States, but the ending shows that there are many who are ready to step in and support newcomers, no matter what their beliefs or where they are from.

*The Evolution of Calpurnia Tate* by Jacqueline Kelly.
Henry Holt & Company. 2009. 352 pages. $16.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0805088415



It is 1899, and Calpurnia Tate, a girl in the middle of six brothers, does not appreciate the activities assigned to her gender. Instead of making pie crusts with Viola, their cook, she would rather be observing grasshoppers in the fields or walking along the river. Henry, her oldest and favorite brother, gives her a notebook, and Callie Vee uses it to record her observations of nature. Of particular note is her often hermit-like grandfather who spends his time alone in his laboratory, perfecting a pecan concoction. Despite his gruff nature, he becomes Calpurnia’s confidante and guide, leading her to discoveries about the creatures and people in her world. His knowledge of Charles Darwin and his connections within the scientific community spur a project between the two that eventually garners attention, drawing the two closer and generating respect from the family. Told with humor and honesty, the story evolves just as Calpurnia does.

*The Mysteries of Beethoven's Hair* by Russell Martin, Lydia Nibley.
Charlesbridge. 2009. 117 pages. $15.95. Informational Science. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1570917140



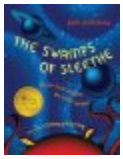

In this reworking of the book first written for adults, the authors not only tell the story of the two hundred year old mysterious cause of Beethoven's mounting physical ailments that left him so wretched, but also trace the journey of his lock of hair, snipped right after his death, from Vienna to Denmark and ultimately to two passionate Beethoven aficionados in Arizona. The resulting book is a combination biography and science and social studies information book that will appeal to young music lovers, scientists and historians alike. While they discuss the science behind the discovery of what probably caused Beethoven's death and the careful research done to trace who had possessed the hair and why, the authors tell an intriguing story filled with fascinating anecdotes about the great man's triumphs and heartbreak. Some discussion of the elements of his personality and episodes in his life are repeated, emphasizing their importance in understanding the man and his talents.

*The Shifter* by Janice Hardy.
HarperCollins. 2009. 370 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0061747041



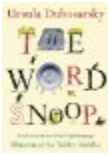

Nya keeps herself alive by stealing, as there is no work, no food, not much of anything other than war and fear in her city. Her special power, being able to take pain into herself from others, is one she shares with her sister who is now apprenticed in the Healers' League. But Nya's "taking" is different; she can't then release the pain into pynvium, the enchanted metal that the League uses to store it. Rather, she can either hold it herself or transfer it to others, an act that is against the law. With her city occupied by an enemy, her sister cloistered with the apprentices, and the rest of her family dead, Nya's life is spinning out of control until, with the help of a handful of others, she uncovers a sinister plot to control pynvium and garner great wealth and power. This first book in a planned series, "The Healing Wars," is full of rip-roaring adventure, an elaborate setting, and great characters.

*The Swamps of Sleethe: Poems from Beyond the Solar System* by Jack Prelutsky, Jimmy Pickering (Illustrator).
0. 2009. Unpaged. $16.99. Poetry. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0375846743



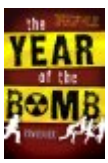

Judging from the title, readers will probably know that Prelutsky's notions of who or what exists in the outer reaches of space is not exactly friendly but fiendish. Each poem offers up horrors for the intrepid space explorer: "gluey fluids fume and froth;" "your brain, turned brittle, splits;" and characters undergo hideous transformations of all kinds. The accompanying dark and spooky illustrations feature waifs with spiky hair and enormous eyes, all the better to ponder the terrible creatures and unwelcoming planets that await them. For word puzzle lovers, some planets are marked with an asterisk, indicating an anagram of a word or phrase describing the terrible place.

*The Word Snoop: A Wild and Witty Tour of the English Language!* by Ursula Dubosarsky, Tohby Riddle (Illustrator).
Dial Books. 2009. 246 pages. $16.99. Informational Arts. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0803734069




The author's passion for words is infectious in this highly entertaining book about topics as diverse as Pig Latin, spoonerisms, and doublespeak. There's so much to discover about the English language in this book designed to turn all readers into word snoops. The author ends her introduction with a challenge: a secret message is hidden in the book. "Farewell, my snoops...and good luck!" Also well designed, the beginning and end of each chapter are set off with red pages. Droll black and white illustrations add to the fun. This book belongs on the shelf of every language arts teacher!

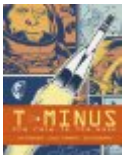
*The Year of the Bomb* by Ronald Kidd.
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. 208 pages. $15.99. Historical Fiction. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 1416958924




“Conspiracies and pod people are only in the movies…right?” Well, Paul and his friends can’t be too sure once filming starts for "The Invasion of the Body Snatchers." Some people are acting strangely even when

the cameras aren't rolling, but that could just be the overactive imagination of four students who love to go to horror movies. With a little detective work and blind luck, Paul and the gang become entangled in something bigger than quiet little Seirra Madre normally would have in store for them. Kidd adroitly blends the reality of McCarthyism with the fictional realm of what-ifs in this book. The question the guys have to eventually ask themselves is "Are we truly helping our country, or are we becoming mindless (like the pod people) in a quest for things that aren't really there?"

*T-Minus: The Race to the Moon* by Jim Ottaviani, Zander Cannon (Illustrator), Kevin Cannon (Illustrator). Aladdin. 2009. 124 pages. $12.99. Informational Science. Intermediate/Adolescent. Multicultural. 1416949607




Readers interested in the Cold War history of the space race between the Russians and the Americans will be fascinated by this fictionalized, historical graphic novel about all the people involved in the herculean effort to land a man on the moon. The use of the T-Minus countdown device, beginning in 1957 with "T-MINUS 12 YEARS" and ending with "T-PLUS..." after the Apollo 11 mission, is quite effective in giving readers a sense of how much time passes between dramatic events. The side columns listing failure after failure of both countries, and the deaths of some astronauts due to these unsuccessful missions and tests, reinforce the danger and the determination of those involved. The behind-the-scenes look at all the arguments over the decisions that are made also highlights the respect the scientists on both sides had for each other. The Soviet and American missions presented make this an intriguing and balanced look at what happened when President Kennedy declared that the U.S. would have a man on the moon within the decade. A glossary on the front and back covers is quite helpful; a page entitled "Did All of This Really Happen?" includes added information and resources for those readers who need to know more.

*Truce: The Day the Soldiers Stopped Fighting* by Jim Murphy.
Scholastic Press. 2009. 116 pages. $19.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. Multicultural. 0545130492




Beginning with a Winston Churchill quote written to his wife pondering what might happen if armies went on strike and refused to fight, Murphy tells the story of the Christmas Truce of 1914, a time when British and German soldiers in the trenches did just that in the face of possibly harsh reprisals by their superiors. He sets the story in the context of the causes of WWI, basing much of what he shares on letters and other personal accounts of that remarkable Christmas when both sides realized just how much they had in common before they were forced to fight once again. Murphy has selected many photos that give life to the soldiers and that time period, some of the horrible aftermath of trench warfare, others of smiling soldiers from one side taken by a soldier from the other on Christmas Day. Murphy's description of this peaceful interlude in the midst of the carnage offers readers hope that humanity still exists in the midst of war and that battle isn't always inevitable.

*Under Siege! Three Children at the Civil War Battle for Vicksburg* by Andrea Warren.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 166 pages. $21.95. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0374312559




The siege and eventual surrender of Vicksburg was key to the Union victory in the Civil War two years later. While the stories of what happened to the Northern and Sounthern troops under Generals Grant and Pemberton are told, Warren focuses on what happened to the townspeople and especially to three children involved: Grant's 12-year-old son Fred, who accompanied his father in battle, and Lucy McRae and Willie Lord who lived in Vicksburg. Readers get a true sense of what battle and its aftermath is like through Fred's accounts of what he witnessed. The terror of living in caves dug into hillsides while under constant barrage is recounted through Lucy and Willie's vivid memories. Many photos, maps and engravings from the period, along with additional short chapters with facts about the Civil War, give added background information. And what happened to the three children after Union troops took over the city? Brief biographies are included for them and other key figures in the book in an afterword.

*Watersmeet* by Ellen Jensen Abbott.
M. Cavendish. 2009. 341 pages. $16.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0761455361



Abisina is an outcast in her village. Her skin and hair are the wrong color, and she has no father. She would be put outside of the village walls if her mother were not the healer. Her tenuous existence is ripped apart when a charismatic new leader visits the village and incites the inhabitants to rise up and kill those who are

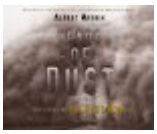
"different." Abisina escapes with only a new knowledge of where her father is--Watersmeet--and her mother's necklace. Determined to find her father, she sets out on a journey that changes her life and her most strongly held beliefs. This first novel is a compelling fantasy, and the planned sequel promises to be so as well.

*When You Reach Me* by Rebecca Stead.
Wendy Lamb Books. 2009. 199 pages. $15.99. Fantasy. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0385737424



It's 1978, and Miranda's life is getting weird. First her best friend Sal gets punched in the face while walking home from school and slowly retreats from their friendship. Then Miranda starts receiving cryptic notes that say things like, "I'm coming to save your friend's life, and my own." Miranda doesn't know what to do about the notes and has her hands full with schoolwork, helping her mom prepare for a TV game show, trying to avoid a pesky vagrant, and finding a new circle of friends. The one constant in her life is her love of the book **A Wrinkle in Time**. She has a weird conversation with Marcus, a new boy at school, about time travel and gradually all the strange events in Miranda's life start to make sense. Readers will feel compelled to go back and re-read the book, looking for clues to the startling and clever ending. Stead's style of writing is refreshing and honest. Give this book to readers who loved Blue Balliet's novels and who enjoy quirky stories with lots of twists and turns.

*Years of Dust: The Story of the Dust Bowl* by Albert Marrin.
Dutton Books. 2009. 125 pages. $22.99. Informational Social Studies. Intermediate/Adolescent. 0. 0525420770



Albert Marrin, as others have before him, tells the poignant story of what happened to the small towns, farmers and their families living in the hardest hit regions during the Dust Bowl. He also sets the disaster against the backdrop of the Great Depression and explores all the ecological decisions that exacerbated the effects of years of drought and high heat. It is his discussion of the unintended consequences of the many decisions that led to the devastation, from those by the "sodbusters" to those who slaughtered the buffalo, that sets this book apart from those previously published for young readers. Along with the many dust colored photos, maps, drawings and other memorabilia, Marrin's extensive research and thorough investigation of the disaster, poignant first-hand accounts and his vivid descriptions of the storms themselves, make the time period come to life. He concludes with an investigation of current pending ecological disasters in places such as the Amazon rain forest and Africa's Sahel, reminding readers that history can repeat itself. A perfect companion to Hesse's **Out of the Dust**.

# Adolescent

*1968* by Michael T. Kaufman.
Roaring Brook Press. 2009. 148 pages. $22.95. Informational Social Studies. Adolescent. 0. 1596434287



The story of this tumultuous year is told through the lens of a New York Times reporter who makes 1968 come to life for adolescent readers through compelling writing and New York Times articles and photos that highlight each chapter. From the Viet Nam War to the assassinations of Robert Kennedy and Martin Luther King, Kaufman shows how the repercussions of all that happened during this one year are still reverberating today. History comes to life in this book that brings a journalistic immediacy to what may seem like long ago events to today's teens. They will gain a great deal of insight into the time period and events that their parents and grandparents still find so haunting.

*After the moment* by Garret Freymann-Weyr.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. 336 pages. $16.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 061860572X



When Leigh agrees to move from New York City to Washington, DC to spend his senior year with his younger stepsister after the death of her father, he expects a long quiet year contemplating life after high school. What he doesn't expect is to fall wildly in love with the exotic Maia who is the exact opposite of his girlfriend at home. Maia holds Leigh at a distance which gives him plenty of time and space to analyze every word and action Maia makes. When Maia is sexually abused by fellow classmates, Leigh is desperate to seek revenge even though Maia has forbidden him to even talk about the incident. Readers who like to penetrate the minds of other teens will enjoy Leigh's journey through unrequited love. This is a beautifully written story of hope, trust and disappointment.

*Bait* by Alex Sanchez.
Simon & Schuster Books for Young Readers. 2009. 239 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. Hispanic. 1416937722



In this wrenching story, Diego, an anguished teenager who deals with his emotional pain by repeatedly cutting himself, is forced to face the horrors of his past and the sexual abuse he suffered by his now dead stepfather when his explosive anger lands him in jail and the office of his compassionate parole officer, Mr. Vidas. The power of dreams and nightmares and the freedom that comes from truths uncovered slowly over the course of many sessions, and even a near-death experience, are realistically and honestly portrayed. The effects of Diego's story and the promise of his future make him a character who won't be readily forgotten.

*Camilla* by Madeleine L'Engle.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 247 pages. $16.95. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0374310319



First published in 1951, this is the story of a teenager who has led a sheltered life with her loving parents in an apartment on the Upper East Side of New York City. Her life takes a sudden turn when she sees her mother passionately kissing another man. She finds comfort in her best friend's brother, who can talk intelligently with her about life, death, God, and her dream of becoming an astronaut some day. She falls in love with him as he introduces her to a world different from the one she has known. A quote from Camilla about the teen years is one young people will relate to: "Fifteen is a difficult age--you lose all the privileges of being a child and get none of the privileges of being grown up."

*Catching fire* by Suzanne Collins.
Scholastic Press. 2009. 391 pages. $17.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 0439023491




Collins's much awaited sequel to **Hunger Games** does not disappoint. At the end of the first novel, readers were left wondering what Katniss and Peeta will encounter when they return home to District Twelve. As winners of the Hunger Games, the two and their families will be treated better, but what of the community? Will the other districts rebel against the Capitol and will District 12 join in? Katniss hears stories about a rebellion, but before any decision can be made, both she and Peeta are summoned back to the Capitol

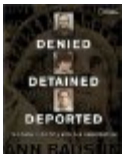
where they will compete in the Quarter Quell, a special edition of the Hunger Games. With so much mistrust and suspicion, who can they trust? Collins's vivid descriptions and likable characters stand out in this exceptional fantasy. Readers are once again left with a cliff hanger and will eagerly await the final book in the trilogy.

*Crossing Stones* by Helen Frost.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 178 pages. $16.99. Poetry. Adolescent. 0. 0374316538



Frost masterfully interweaves the rhyme schemes of her poems and the stories of four teens in two close Michigan families living across the creek from each other who are dealing with the violence of WWI and women's suffrage. While Muriel's voice predominates in zigzag poems that reflect the fact that her "mind meanders like the creek," her brother Ollie and best friend Emma's "cupped-hand sonnets" deftly give their perspectives on the tumultuous time for their families as well. The story flows as easily as the creek that slips over the crossing stones that connect the families and their fates. Readers will empathize with these teens who face hard times and difficult decisions with enduring love and determination.

*Denied, Detained, Deported: Stories from the Dark Side of American Immigration* by Ann Bausum.
National Geographic Society. 2009. 112 pages. $21.95. Informational Social Studies. Adolescent. Multicultural. 1426303327




To introduce this timely topic, a winsome photo of two little girls looking out of a ship's portal is followed by Emma Lazarus's famous poem, "The New Collosus," and a new poem by Naomi Shihab Nye. The earlier poem's famous lines - "Give me your tired, your poor" - are countered with Nye's: "But not too tired, not too poor." The author deftly explores a side of immigration not usually dealt with in books for young adult readers through the stories of real people who may not have always been treated very well in the process for a number of reasons. This is a comprehensive look at our fear of others, whether Chinese, Japanese, Mexicans, Jews or anyone else who raised suspicion during any given time period. The historic photos enhance readers' responses to this critical look at what happens when the dream of American immigration is not fulfilled.

*Fade* by Lisa McMann.
Simon Pulse. 2009. 248 pages. $15.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 1416953582



This eerie sequel to **Wake** begins with Janie rushing into her house at 1:31AM and immediately finding herself in the middle of one of her mother's familiar dreams, one more pleasant than the nightmares soon to follow. Janie's dream catching abilities soon pit her against a dark and disturbing force, a responsibility that her boyfriend Cabe has trouble accepting. The suspense builds as Janie also discovers the awful truth about the perils to her health inherent in her use of her strange ability to see other people's dreams and nightmares. The case solved and their differences resolved, Janie and Cabe graduate from high school. "It's just the end of some things. And the beginning of others." Readers can look forward to a third book in the series.

*Fire* by Kristen Cashore.
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. 461 pages. $17.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 0803734611



In this prequel to last year's wildly popular fantasy **Graceling**, readers are introduced to another strong female character, Fire. While the characters in Graceling have special talents which set them apart from other humans (main character Katsa could kill anyone at any time), Fire is a human monster who can read and control minds. This ability makes her a high demand item, and many sects in the kingdom want her to join their forces. Fire's loyalty lies with Archer and his family, and after traveling across country to save a young girl, Fire and her new charge must fight harsh elements and opposing armies to return home. There's lots of romance and adventure in this well developed fantasy. Cashore's world is fully realized, and the characters are engaging and alive. This story is as satisfying as **Graceling**, and is one in which readers can completely lose themselves.

*Front and Center* by Catherine Gilbert Murdock.
Houghton Mifflin. 2009. 254 pages. $16.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0618959823



In this third book of the "Dairy Queen" trilogy, D.J., now a high school junior, is faced with some life-altering decisions. Can she get over her fear and play D1 basketball for the U of MN or UW Madison? It would be so much easier to play for a D III college. Should she declare herself as her good friend Beaner's

girlfriend when she can't stop thinking about her ex, Brian? While it may seem to outsiders that she's living the perfect life because of all her opportunities, shy D.J. is really struggling with all the decisions she has to make, especially when pressured by her older disabled brother Win to do what he thinks is right for her. The thoughtful ending is very realistic and seems just right for this talented farm girl who's ready to take a chance on life.

*If I stay* by Gayle Forman.
Dutton Juvenile. 2009. 208 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0525421033



On a beautiful February morning Mia and her family take advantage of an unexpected snow day and decide to visit friends who live nearby. Mia has been thinking a lot about the choices that will be available to her in the spring when she graduates from high school. All those choices are taken away from her when the leisurely drive turns into a disaster. Mia is the only survivor of the car crash, and as she lays unconscious in the hospital, she reminisces about her life and family. Everyone who visits encourages and pleads with her to hang in there and stay with them. Mia must make the difficult decision to either join her family or to continue to live, but live without them. Full of humor, hope and love, teens looking for a tear jerker will find much to savor and think about in this lyrically written book.

*Just Another Hero* by Sharon M. Draper.
Atheneum Books. 2009. 280 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. Multicultural. 1416907009




The final book in the trilogy preceded by **November Blues** and **The Battle of Jericho** begins with Arielle intervening in a shocking bullying incident involving Osrick, continues with her tentative reintegration into her group of friends following the tragic consequences of the hazing ritual, and moves at a quick pace to the harrowing conclusion that explores the idea of what constitutes a hero. Subplots include how the high school seniors deal with personal demons and their own complicated friendships; how Kofi's relationship with his ineffectual parents clouds his future plans; and how Arielle confronts her sadistic, controlling step-father. Draper has created characters and high school situations that seem so real that readers will be reluctant to see their stories end.

*King of the Screwups* by K.L. Going.
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 310 pages. $17.00. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0152062580



Neither Liam nor his always-in-denial mother, a famously beautiful former model, want to admit what will soon be obvious to any teen reader: they are just alike. Those same readers will also realize long before Liam does that his unrelentingly hard-hearted, coldly calculating father is the reason why Liam always screws up and can never please him no matter what he does to make amends. After being kicked out of the house right before his senior year after an absurd, drunken sexual encounter, Liam finally comes to terms with who he is while living with his gay uncle, whom he constantly refers to as Aunt Pete, and pursuing the girl next door whom everyone at his new high school, where he is wildly popular no matter how hard he tries not to be, thinks is weird. Ultimately, this is a poignant story about accepting who you are and being comfortable in your own skin, a message that can't be relayed too often to teen readers.

*Marcelo in the Real World* by Francisco X. Stork.
A. A. Levine Books. 2009. 312 pages. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. Mexico. 0545054745



Marcelo Sandoval knows he is different. Some people would say he is mentally ill but Marcelo is actually a teen with Asperger's Syndrome. He leads a pretty ordered life, goes to a special school where he feels comfortable and has his hobbies. But his father wants more than just a routine life for Marcelo. Mr. Sandoval gives Marcelo an ultimatum: work for one summer for his corporate law office (to get a taste of real life...) and if he succeeds, Marcelo can go back to his old school. If he fails, then it's off to the local high school. Shortly after Marcelo begins work he discovers a secret that his father has kept hidden. Marcelo must decide to either expose his father, and accept the dire consequences, or keep quiet and live with the awful truth. Beautifully written and laced with emotion, readers will eagerly go along for the ride with Marcelo into the real world.

*Mare's War* by Tanita S. Davis.
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. 343 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. African-American. 0375857141



As they reluctantly travel on a summer road trip with their grandmother, Mare, sisters Tali and Octavia are regaled with the story of what her life was like as a member of one of the only African American batallions of the Women's Army Corps to go overseas during WWII. Chapters alternate between "Then" and "Now," and between Octavia's voice and that of her grandmother. The initially strained relationships of the teen-aged sisters with each other and with their charismatic grandmother ring true, as does the growing respect they share as the young Mare's dramatic story, and that of her family and WAC friends, unfolds. The ending, where Mare puts "the past and darkness behind her," is just right.

*Moribito II: Guardian of the Darkness* by Nahoko Uehashi, Yuko Shimizu (Illustrator), Cathy Hirano (Translator).
Arthur A. Levine Books. 2009. 245 pages. $17.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. Asia (Far East). 0545102952




Since she was saved from being killed when just six years old, Balsa has dealt with the treachery that has haunted her since her father's murder. She returns to her native Kanbal only to learn that Jiguro, the exited man who nobly saved her after promising her father that he would, has been unjustly labelled a murderer. Balsa's intense encounters with evil characters make this an appealing book for readers who love hero tales, Kung Fu films and Japanese martial arts along with folkloric characters and great struggles between good and evil.

*Muchacho* by Louanne Johnson.
Alfred A. Knopf. 2009. 197 pages. $15.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. Latino-American. 0375861173



As a junior at an alternative high school in a drug-plagued part of a city in New Mexico, Eddie Corazon prides himself in being a "badass" juvenile delinquent, walking a fine line to maintain his persona while not getting into serious trouble. With the help of his first real girlfriend, who is college bound and believes in him, and a former teacher, he's able to break away from the violence in his past that is revealed in flashbacks. When contrasted to others at his school who don't miraculously change, his transition from disaffected teen with no chance to even graduate from high school to hopeful poet by the end of the book is believable. High school students will recognize Eddie and his contemporaries and their seemingly insolvable problems.

*North of Beautiful* by Justina Chen Headley.
Little, Brown. 2009. 384 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0316025054



Sixteen-year-old Terra has beautiful hair, a winning smile and a killer body, but she also has a port wine stain on her cheek. She never leaves the house without heavy make-up, so few people know her secret. Terra has spent a lifetime feeling like an outsider while searching for another way to remove the birthmark. Terra and her mother are returning home from a doctor visit when they literally run into goth-boy Jacob and his mother. This event proves to be a turning point in both Terra's and her mother's lives, and soon the four of them are planning a trip to China so Jacob can visit the orphanage where he lived, and Terra can visit her brother who works there. Each of them confronts their insecurities and comes home ready to battle their demons. Terra decides to accept who she is and to stop hiding her birthmark, and her mother resolves to be a stronger person and deal with her abusive husband. This well written, moving book has strongly defined characters who will stay with the reader long after the book is finished.

*Partly Cloudy: Poems of Love and Longing* by Gary Soto.
Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. 2009. 100 pages. $16.00. Poetry. Adolescent. 0. 0152063013



With great empathy and deft ability at recreating young teen voices, Soto explores the yearning and heartbreak of young love in all its guises in two sections of free verse poetry: "A Girl's Tears, Her Songs" and "A Boy's Body, His Words." Soto knows how fickle love can be at this age, how strongly felt, the ecstasy and pain, exhaustion and danger of young teenaged love. Middle school readers will find these poems very accessible and may be moved to express their own feelings about love after reading Soto's insightful poetry.

*Sacred Scars* by Kathleen Duey.
Atheneum Books. 2009. 554 pages. $18.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 0689840950



Readers of this second book in the Resurrection of Magic series, a sequel to the highly acclaimed **Skin Hunger**, will find that both Sadima and Franklin, and Hahp and Gerrard generations later, are facing even more dire challenges than in the first book. They're physically and psychologically tortured by Somiss, who is driven to discover and perfect the old magic no matter what the consequences. Their stories, told in alternating chapters, leave the reader on edge throughout the book. People have died; children are caged and starving; the scars are many and deep. The future looks bleak for everyone involved. The ending leaves all the characters in precarious circumstances, only to be resolved in the final book of the trilogy.

*Shiver* by Maggie Stiefvater.
Scholastic Press. 2009. 292 pages. $17.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 0545123267




Tension builds throughout this story of the power of love in overcoming seemingly insurmountable odds. Grace is attacked by wolves - who are actually a pack of werewolves - as a child but is saved by one yellow-eyed wolf who continues to protect her each winter from his sanctuary in the woods. When the weather warms, the werewolf becomes Sam in human form. The engrossing and entirely believable story is told in alternating chapters (whose titles tell the current temperature, foreshadowing change since Sam's transformation is triggered by the cold) from Grace and Sam's points of view. Facts about wolves and the mythology of werewolves are deftly interwoven into the plot as Grace discovers all she needs to know about the man/wolf she loves.

*Solace of the Road* by Siobhan Dowd.
David Fickling Books. 2009. 261 pages. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. Great Britain. 0375849718



When she is removed from her group home to go live with a couple who could become even more than foster parents, Holly decides that her life as she's known it is over. Reinventing herself as Solace, Solace of the road, she sets off for Ireland to find her mother, who disappeared years ago. What she finds is the unhappy truth about her mother, a tentatively loving relationship between herself and her foster parents, and a new understanding of who she really is.

*The Chosen One* by Carol Lynch Williams.
Saint Martins Press. 2009. 224 pages. $16.95. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0312555113



At first Kyra and her family are stunned to hear that she has been chosen. She's not quite 14 and already a husband has been selected for her. No one ever questions the Prophet's decisions, so Kyra must ready herself to become the seventh wife of her father's older brother Hyrum. Kyra's emotions quickly run from shock to anger to fear. She tells her mother that she does not want to marry Hyrum, but her parents stress complete obedience to the Prophet. When her friend Joshua asks Prophet Childs for Kyra, Joshua is severely beaten. Kyra is next; Hyrum is given permission to use physical force to 'train' Kyra. After Joshua runs from the compound, Kyra decides that she must run too in order to survive. Brutually honest and heart wrenching, this story of growing up female in a polygamist sect is a rare look into a secret world.

*The Espressologist* by Kristina Springer.
Farrar Straus & Giroux. 2009. 184 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 0374322287



Have you ever heard the phrase "You are what you eat?" What about "You are what you drink?" Working as a barista at the local Wired Joe's, Jane starts to notice trends about her customers' personalities and the drinks they order. She then keeps her own Espressology notebook and realizes that she might be on to something. Eventually, people get wind of her talent and decide she should start match-making based on drink compatibility. Springer takes an interesting idea and creates a light-hearted tale of friendship, romance, and frothy delights.

*The Eternal Smile* by Gene Luen Yang, Derek Kirk Kim (Illustrator).
First Second. 2009. 170 pages. $16.95. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 1596431563



The story line and characters in "Duncan's Kingdom," the first in a collection of three graphic short stories in the book, follows all the familiar elements of hero tales of old, including a vile frog enemy, a beautiful princess (who fortunately in this case doesn't have to kiss the frog), and a young male hero on a quest to win her as his bride. The discovery of a Snappy Cola bottle in the midst of this fairy tale leads to an abrupt change of setting and a huge dose of reality. Yang and Kim show the influences of the fantasy world on reality in the other two stories as well, using surprising twists and turns in the action to explore right and wrong, and the mundane and the extraordinary, in the lives of the main characters. Lovers of graphic novels who are familiar with the author and illustrators' earlier works (**American Born Chinese** and **Same Difference and Other Stories**) will welcome this clever collaboration; the two may also win over new readers with their well crafted, dramatic stories that blend reality and fantasy in unique ways.

*The Forest of Hands and Teeth* by Carrie Ryan.
Delacorte Press. 2009. 320 pages. $17.99. Fantasy. Adolescent. 0. 0385736819




As a young girl Mary heard many stories her mother told of the ocean and of a far distant world. That time and place is so foreign that most villagers no longer believe an outside world exists. But Mary clings to the details of the tales and hopes one day to see the ocean. For now her ordered world is confined to the village which is completely surrounded by the forest where the unconsecrated dwell. When the fence around the village is breached and people are killed by the zombies, Mary and her friends are fortunate to escape. But where will they go? Is there a world beyond the forest? What is it like? Mary must decide to follow her dream of finding life outside the village or return home to face an uncertain reality.

*The King's Rose* by Alisa Libby.
Dutton Juvenile. 2009. 320 pages. $17.99. Historical Fiction. Adolescent. Great Britain. 0525479708



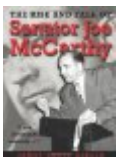
From the very beginning of the novel, Libby creates a world that is bound by English history, yet she does not give away anything of what is to come. Catherine Howard is a hopeful young lady who finds herself the center of King Henry's attention. This is an interesting tale of a young woman trying to figure out who she is and what she wants while caught in a web of political intrigue and moral ambiguity. What does it mean to love? What does it mean to be a woman? Henry's Queen?

*The Orange Houses* by Paul Griffin.
Dial Books. 2009. 147 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. Multicultural. 080373346




Beginning with a poignant poem and the fact that an hour after he wrote it, Jimmi was hung by vigilantes, the quick-paced thriller counts down the next 27 days until the hanging that's been foretold. Besides Jimmi, an 18-year-old, emotionally disturbed vet, there's Mik, a 15-year-old hearing impaired girl existing as a social outsider at her school, bullied by a box cutter carrying teen and her posse, and gentle Fatima, a young illegal African immigrant who's seen her own share of physical violence evidenced by her two missing fingers and the scar on her cheek. How these three become friends and find hope in their seemingly hopeless situations propels readers to the harrowing ending. Not only do they survive, but there is some promise of a happier future.

*The Rise and Fall of Senator Joe McCarthy* by James Cross Giblin.
Clarion Books. 2009. 294 pages. $22.00. Biography/Memoir. Adolescent. 0. 0618610588




Giblin provides the rich historical and political context needed to understand why McCarthy declared, "I can investigate anybody!" McCarthy's unprecedented political power, set against the perceived Communist threat in government and even the arts, made him one of the most feared or admired men in 1950's America, depending upon a person's point of view at the time. The use of many photos of all those involved along with some political cartoons from the period adds valuable information. The depth of Giblin's research enhances the riveting story of a time not so long ago when many in America were afraid.

*Vast Fields of Ordinary* by Nick Burd.
Dial Books for Young Readers. 2009. 309 pages. $16.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. GLBT. 0803733402



Dade Hamilton has just graduated from high school and the long summer ahead of him looks mighty bleak. He feels trapped in a boring suburb working at a boring job and in a relationship that's going nowhere fast. So called 'boyfriend' Pablo has not declared his homosexuality and denies he knows Dade to his friends. To complicate matters, Dade's parents are heading for a divorce, and his mother has retreated into the land of drugs. But then Dade meets openly gay Alex, whose allure is too strong for Dade to resist. Dade is drawn into Alex's dark world, selling drugs, going to parties, and living on the edge. Suddenly the summer is not so boring after all. This is Burd's debut novel, and it is full of authentic characters and true-to-life dialogue. Dade's inner turmoil is real and poignant. It's refreshing to read a novel with gay characters who are not overly melodramatic and who live in the end.

*Wintergirls* by Laurie Halse Anderson.
Viking Children's Books. 2009. 288 pages. $17.99. Contemporary Realistic Fiction. Adolescent. 0. 067001110X




Lia and Cassie have been friends forever. But now in high school they have grown apart, even though they both suffer and struggle with their eating disorders. On the outside Lia seems to be doing better after treatment, but inwardly the self-loathing is still there. When Lia learns that Cassie has died, her lies and deceptions begin to fall apart, and Lia is caught up in a downward spiral that even she cannot control. Vivid descriptions of Lia's methods to deceive both herself and her family, as well as brutally honest self-assessments, make this a difficult but compelling read. For mature teens.